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	CHARTERED ACCOUNTANT

NORTHERN SETTLEMENT SERVICES LIMITED

(formerly the Migrant Resource Centre of Newcastle & the Hunter Region Ltd.)

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NOTICE IS HEREBY GIVEN OF THE
23rd ANNUAL GENERAL MEETING
OF
NORTHERN SETTLEMENT SERVICES LIMITED
(formerly the Migrant Resource Centre of Newcastle & the Hunter
Region)
TO BE HELD ON THURSDAY 29 NOVEMBER 2007
AT 8 CHAUCER STREET HAMILTON
AT 11.00am

- 1. OPENING & WELCOME BY CHAIRMAN, MR HENRY CHAN**
- 2. APOLOGIES**
- 3. MINUTES OF 2006 AGM**
- 4. BUSINESS ARISING**
- 5. PRESENTATION OF REPORTS**
- 6. CONFIRMATION OF AUDITORS**
- 7. ELECTION OF NSS MANAGEMENT COMMITTEE**
- 8. GENERAL BUSINESS**
- 9. CLOSE & LIGHT REFRESHMENTS**

NSS MANAGEMENT COMMITTEE

Chairperson	Mr Henry Chan
Vice Chairperson	Mr William Simanowsky
Treasurer	Mr John McLennan
Assistant Treasurer	Ms Trudy Mills Evers
Secretary	Ms Alina Kizeweter
Assistant Secretary	Ms Sania Young
Member	Fthr Nicholas Zervas
Member	Mr Zoran Vasiljevic
Member	Mr Ivan Klopccic OAM
Member	Mr Makur Marial Leeth.

STAFF

Director	Ms Violetta Walsh OAM
Assistant Director/ Migration Agent /	
Special Projects Team Leader	Ms Lulu Tantos
Migration Agent	Ms Irina Lupish
Specialist Case Worker / OH&S Consultant	Ms Helen Buchanan
Financial Controller	Ms Arlene Richards
Assistant Financial Controller	Ms Marianne Mohr
Office Manager	Ms Sinead Buckley
Administrators / Information & Referral Workers	Ms Renee McLean
	Ms Silvia Ruano
Information & Referral Worker	Ms Tima 'Oto
Rural Projects Team Leader	Mr Alex Burns
Hunter Outreach SGP Worker	Ms Miza Torlakovic
New England SGP Worker (Tamworth)	Mr Home Phanoraj
New England SGP Worker (Armidale)	Ms Judith Roberts
Links to Learning Coordinator	Ms Michelle Steele
	Mr Chris Hudson
Aged Care Projects Team Leader/	
Community Aged Care Packages Coordinator	Ms Sue Hristov
Community Aged Care Packages Coordinator 2	Ms Lupe Fonua
Community Aged Care Packages Coordinator 3	Ms Tima 'Oto
CVS Coordinator	Ms Ann Dupree (retired)
	Ms Enza diStefano
MSSS Office Manager	Ms Sharlene Huber
Senior Coordinator	Ms Sandra Wingrave
Coordinator	Ms Olivia Fuente
African Projects Team Leader / CPO	Mr Michael Adderley
African Youth Worker	Mr Marial Fieg
African Welfare Worker	Mr Simon Pabek
African Family Support Workers (Families First)	Mr Zachary Karithi
	Mr Mohamed Kamara
	Ms J Ntahomvukiye
	Ms Zeni Edmunds
Volunteer Resource Worker	Mr Paul Sidebottom
	Mr Michael Freund
Welfare Projects Team Leader/ Filipino Welfare Worker	Ms Petrona Kelly
Russian Welfare Worker	Ms Elena Ferguson
Thai Welfare Worker	Ms Nellie Srisurapon
Pacific Islander Welfare Worker (Samoan)	Ms Juanita Loli
Pacific Islander Welfare Worker (Tongan)	Ms Sara Stankovic
Multicultural Family Worker (Families First)	Ms Devika Wijewardene
Migrant & Refugee Women's Worker	Ms Zeni Edmunds

**MINUTES OF THE 22nd ANNUAL GENERAL MEETING OF THE
MIGRANT RESOURCE CENTRE OF NEWCASTLE & THE HUNTER REGION
LIMITED, HELD AT THE MIGRANT RESOURCE CENTRE PREMISES ON
WEDNESDAY 29 NOVEMBER 2006 AT 11.00AM.**

Present: as per list attached.

1. H Chan welcomed everyone present & thanked them for attending, on behalf of the MRC Management Committee.

2. APOLOGIES:

Committee Members:	Z Vasiljevic
MRC Members:	M Milevski
	I Lupish
	J Loli
	L Moore
	D Wijewardene
	A Burns
	L Totoeva
	Z Karithi

3. MINUTES OF THE 2005 AGM:

MINUTES ACCEPTED:

Proposed:	I Klopacic
Seconded:	S Young

4. BUSINESS ARISING:

V Walsh reported that the Centre is investigating the feasibility of attaining charitable status. V Walsh stated that in light of the changes in funding since 01/07/06 it is time for the MRC to move away from its current model and seek status as a PBI as referred to in the Agenda.

V Walsh informed the meeting that the Centre's operations in the New England Region have been expanded and that outreach is now a major part of our work.

5. PRESENTATION OF REPORTS:

Chairman's Report: H Chan - Report tabled & accepted as read.

V Walsh – Centre Director: Report tabled & accepted as read.

- V Walsh said that she is happy to see partnership between MRC and MNC as it will make both agencies stronger.
- Centre is optimistic about receiving extra CACP packages for Polish and Chinese clients.
- V Walsh offered her thanks to management and staff for their support.

I Lupish – Migration Agent, Community Project Officer, Russian Welfare & L Tantos – Deputy Director, Migration Agent: Report tabled & accepted as read.

- I Lupish currently covering position in Armidale.
- Migration is a constant stream and MRC is keen to continue this relationship with DIMA.

A Burns – CSSS Rural Support Worker: Report tabled & accepted as read.

- A Burns stated that he is optimistic of the MRC's continuing role in rural areas as it has some very valuable input to offer.

M Torlakovic – CSSS2 Welfare Outreach Worker: Report tabled & accepted as read.

T 'Oto – Refugee & Humanitarian Entrant Worker: Report tabled & accepted as read.

S Pabek – CSSS Sudanese & African Communities Support Worker: Report tabled & accepted as read.

- Very high numbers of issues being dealt with.

M Fieg – CSSS African Youth Worker: Report tabled & accepted as read.

- Many problems with young Africans in schools, complex cases and co-ordination between agencies is vital. V Walsh stated that the workers efforts were to be commended and the Committee confirmed that they are aware of the issues being faced and are looking at options to provide the best services on limited resources.

L Moore – CSSS New England: Report tabled & accepted as read.

I Nduwamunga & Z Karithi – African Family Support Workers: Report tabled & accepted as read.

- 3 communities being looked after by this project with poor educational background, high ESL needs, translations etc.
- Ongoing problems – much work to be done.

C Johnston – Refugee orientation DVD- Project Officer: Report tabled & accepted as read.

- C Johnston remarked that the production of the DVD would not have been possible without the support received from other staff. A very useful resource.

P Kelly – Filipino Welfare Project: Report tabled & accepted as read.

D Wijewardene – Multicultural Family Support Project – Families First: Report tabled & accepted as read.

S Hristov & L Fonua – Community Aged Care Packages: Report tabled & accepted as read.

C Follett – Hunter Multicultural Respite Service: Report tabled & accepted as read.

- Successful service review completed
- Funding secured for 3 years
- Thanks to all staff and management.

O Fuente & S Huber – HACC Multicultural Social Support Service – Central Coast: Report tabled & accepted as read.

- Successful service review.
- Committee is very happy with the growth in the service.

A Dupree – Community Visitors Scheme: Report tabled & accepted as read.

- A Dupree remarked on the huge achievement of the Centre that is, 25 years of service.

M Addereley– New Land New Laws Project: Report tabled & accepted as read.

- Project going very well and is receiving valuable support from the legal community.
- Thanks to the African workers for their contribution.

STAFF REPORTS ACCEPTED:

Proposer:

T Mills Evers

Seconded:

S Young

FINANCIAL REPORTS:

- Mr Mark O'Connor from Cutcher & Neale presented a brief report on the MRC's financial dealings over the past 12 months. He acknowledged that the reports are now in a different format to reflect International Accounting standards. Administration costs have reduced. He concluded by saying that the report reflects an expansion of the Centre's activities.

FINANCIAL REPORTS ACCEPTED:

Proposed: I Klopčić
Seconded: A Kizeweter

6. APPOINTMENT OF COMPANY AUDITORS:

Proposed: L Tantos
Seconded: T Mills
Evers

- H Chan confirmed that Cutcher & Neale would be retained as the Centre's Auditor for 2007.

7. ELECTION OF MRC MANAGEMENT COMMITTEE

1. Mr William Simanowsky
2. Ms Trudy Mills-Evers
3. Ms Alina Kizeweter
4. Ms Sania Young
5. Mr Zoran Vasiljevic
6. Mr Henry Chan
7. Fthr Nicholas Zervas
8. Mr Ivan Klopčić
9. Mr Makuer Makuer Marial Leeth
10. Mr John McLennan

The 10 nominations were duly elected as the 2007 MRC Management Committee.

8. SPECIAL BUSINESS:

- V Walsh introduced the MRC's Honorary Legal Advisor to explain the necessary changes to be made via a Special Resolution in view of the realignment of Centre funding since 01/07/06. The proposed new name for the organisation will be Northern Settlement Services Ltd. This name has been chosen because the "Migrant Resource Centre" as an entity effectively ceased to exist on 01/07/06 and also a name change would better reflect our area of operations and the purpose of our activities.

- M Walsh (Honorary Legal Advisor) outlined the need for a change to the constitution as MRC is a company whereas these days charitable bodies are incorporated by association. M Walsh explained that some aspects of the 1984 constitution has been refined and further that the organisation intended to apply for DGI status (Gift Tax Deductibility) allowing us to follow up avenues of funding unavailable to MRC's. There would also be benefits for the staff.
- M Walsh explained that various conditions set out in the 1984 constitution would need to be removed in order for this process to begin.
- M Walsh drew attention to the proposed new name for the MRC which redefines the catchment area of the agency detailed in paragraph 3 (1) and (2). He noted that a special clause would be inserted to the Memorandum of Association detailing what would happen in the event of the winding up of the agency.
- M Walsh referred to Clause 15 which details the Tax Office requirements as to the way in which the organisation would deal with any donations.
Motion moved to adopt Special resolution - attached

Proposed: H Chan
Seconded: B Simanowsky

Motion accepted at Annual General Meeting on 29/11/06

Changes will be incorporated into constitution via a Memorandum of Association. Name change will take effect on registration with ASIC.

9. GENERAL BUSINESS

- H Chan offered the appreciation of the Committee to the Administration section on the production of the Annual Report. He also thanked DIMA consultant Ian Johns for his interest and consultancy help throughout his tenure.
- V Walsh informed the meeting that the former Office Manager had recently given birth to a healthy baby boy named Erik.
- V Walsh also informed those present that the Centre was looking at a restructure in the delegation of tasks with a system of 6 teams to give a more focused approach.
- V Walsh also reported a growth in the Russian Welfare area however no apparent funding to service the needs of this community. H Chan said the committee looked forward to progress on these things

MEETING FINISHED AT 12.20PM

**MIGRANT RESOURCE CENTRE
OF NEWCASTLE AND HUNTER REGION LIMITED**

SPECIAL RESOLUTION

RESOLVED as a Special Resolution that:

1. The name of the company be changed to “Northern Settlement Services Limited”.
2. The constitution of the company, being the Memorandum of Association (“MA”) and Articles of Association (“AA”) of the company, be altered as follows.
3. In clause 1. of the MA delete sub-clauses (1) and (2), and substitute :
 - (1) The name of the company is “Northern Settlement Services Limited” (hereinafter called “the Agency”).
 - (2) The catchment area of the Agency is the Local Government Area of Newcastle, the Hunter region (being the Local Government Areas of Lake Macquarie, Greater Cessnock, Dungog, Scone, Singleton, Merriwa, Muswellbrook, Maitland, Port Stephens and Murrumbidgee), the Central Coast region (being the Local Government Areas of the Shire of Wyong and the City of Gosford), the New England region (being the City of Armidale and surrounding districts), and the Tamworth region (being the City of Tamworth and surrounding districts).
4. In each and every place in the MA and in the AA in which the word “Centre” appears, delete the same and substitute “Agency”, and where “Migrant Resource Centre of Newcastle and Hunter Region Limited” appears substitute “Northern Settlement Services Limited”.
5. In clause 2. of the MA delete sub-clauses (1), (2) and (3), and substitute :
 - (1) As the agency’s primary purpose and principal object, to directly deliver services to ensure the relief from poverty distress and misfortune of those settling into the Agency’s catchment area as refugees and migrants, working towards the successful settlement and long-term welfare of such refugees and migrants.
 - (2) To do all such things as are necessary or appropriate towards achieving the said purpose and object.
6. In clause 3. of the MA, delete the last paragraph commencing “The provisions”.
7. Delete clause 5. of the MA.
8. In clause 1. of the AA, delete the definitions of “Hunter Region” and “The Code” and “the Unincorporated Centre”.
9. In clause 6(a) of the AA, delete “Newcastle or the Hunter Region” and substitute “the Agency’s catchment area”.
10. In clauses 25. and 27. and 79(a) of the AA, delete “Code” and substitute “relevant law”

11. In clause 29. of the AA, delete “Section 241 of the Code” and substitute “relevant law”.
12. In clauses 56(a) and 56(c) of the AA, delete “the Code” and substitute “any relevant law”.
13. In clause 58(g) of the AA, delete the words commencing with “provided” and continuing to the end.
14. Insert in the AA after clause 83, the following new additional clause as clause 83A. :
 - (1) The Agency shall maintain for the primary purpose and principal object of the Agency a fund called the Gift Fund to which gifts of money or property for such primary purpose are to be made, and to which any money received by the Agency because of those gifts is to be credited, and that does not receive any other money or property.
 - (2) Certain kinds of money and property must not go to the Gift Fund, including income from sponsorship or commercial activities, or the proceeds of such things as raffles, auctions or fund-raising dinners.
 - (3) The Agency shall use the gifts made to the Gift Fund and any money received because of those gifts only for the primary purpose of the Agency.
 - (4) At the first occurrence of the winding up of the Gift Fund or the Agency ceasing to be a Deductible Gift Recipient as defined by any Commonwealth Taxation Act, any surplus assets of the Gift Fund shall be transferred to such one or more Deductible Gift Recipients as approved by the Australian Taxation Office under any Commonwealth Taxation Act as the Agency decides.
 - (5) The Agency shall maintain a separate bank account for the Gift Fund.

ATTENDANCE LIST 30 NOVEMBER 2006

Name	Community/Group/Organisation
Catherine Hobbs	Centrelink
John McLennan	Member – MRC
Amany Beshay	MNC
Christine Follett	MRC
Tima Oto	MRC
A Kizeweter	MRC Management Committee
Polish Community	
W Simanowsky	MRC Management Committee
Ukrainian Community	
Zenaida Edmonds	MRC/MNC
Henry Chan	MRC Management Committee
Chinese Community	
Denise Hodgson	Centrelink
Michael Walsh	Honorary Legal Adviser
Trudy Mills Evers	MRC Management Committee
Ivan Klopac	MRC Management Committee
Slovenian Community	
Sue Hristov	MRC
Lupe Fonua	MRC
Helen Buchanan	MRC
Paul Sidebottom	MRC
Cathy Johnston	MRC
Suzanna Goldfinch	MRC
Pet Kelly	MRC
Sinead Buckley	MRC
Arlene Richards	MRC
Carla Silva	MRC
Olivia Fuente	MSSS-MRC
Sania Young	MRC Management Committee
Lulu Tantos	MRC
Violetta Walsh	MRC
Miza Torlakovic	MRC
Sharlene Huber	MSSS-MRC
Michael Todd	Macedonian Day Care
Vitaly Lupish	Russian Community & ECC
Johanna Dupree	MRC and Dutch Society

OVERVIEW OF 2007

NORTHERN SETTLEMENT SERVICES LIMITED

Funding Partnerships throughout 2007

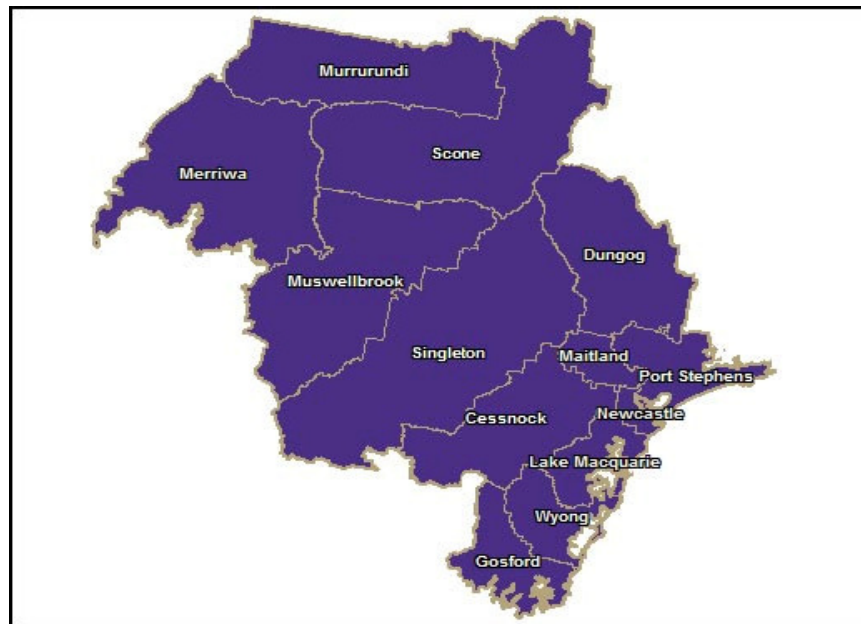
Department of Immigration and Citizenship
 NSW Department of Community Services
 Commonwealth Department of Health and Ageing
 NSW Department of Ageing Disability and Home Care
 Federal Attorney General Department
 Community Development Support Expenditure (Registered Clubs NSW)
 Department of Fair Trading
 NRMA

Clients by Ethnic Background

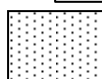
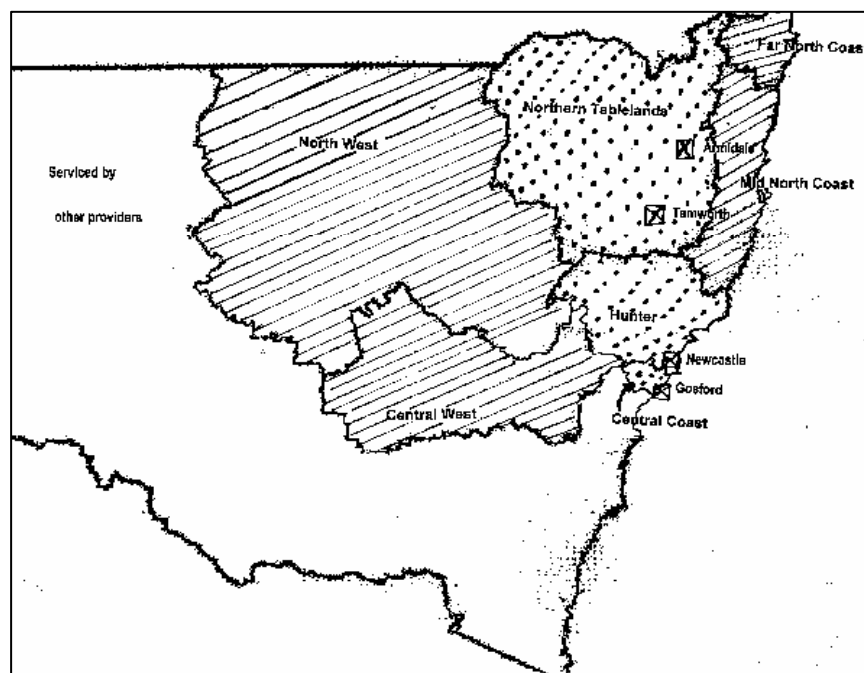
Albania	Egypt	Liberia	Russia
Afghanistan	Fiji	Lithuania	Scotland
Algeria	Finland	Malaysia	Serbia
Australia	France	Macedonia	Sierra Leone
Austria	Germany	Mexico	Singapore
Argentina	Greece	Montenegro	Slovenia
Bangladesh	Honduras	Morocco	South Africa
Botswana	Hong Kong	Netherlands	Spain
Bosnia	Hungary	Nepal	Sri Lanka
Brazil	India	New Zealand	Sudan
Burundi	Indonesia	Nigeria	Sweden
Canada	Ireland	Norway	Switzerland
Chile	Iran	Panama	Syria
China	Iraq	Pakistan	Tahiti
Colombia	Italy	Papua New Guinea	Taiwan
Congo (DRC)	Japan	Paraguay	Thailand
Croatia	Jordan	Persia	Tonga
Cyprus	Kazakhstan	Peru	Turkey
Czech Republic	Kenya	Poland	Ukraine
Dominican Republic	Korea	Portugal	Uruguay
East Timor	Kuwait	Philippines	USA
England	Latvia	Rwanda	Venezuela
El Salvador	Lebanon	Romania	Vietnam

NORTHERN SETTLEMENT SERVICES LIMITED OUR SERVICE REGIONS & OFFICE LOCATIONS

HUNTER OUTREACH



OFFICE LOCATIONS & SERVICE REGIONS



**Areas serviced by NSS offices at Hamilton
Gosford, Armidale & Tamworth**



Areas serviced by NSS outreach workers



Chairman's Report

Henry Chan

We certainly live in interesting times! I am very conscious that I am preparing my report against the backdrop of a very hard fought Federal Election, whose outcome will be known when we gather for our meeting, just 4 days later.

I am sure all of us with an interest in multicultural affairs have been looking hard for any policy announcements from the protagonists about matters dear to our hearts, such as the enhancement of life opportunities for our new settlers, and recognition of the value of multiculturalism to the social, cultural and economic life of this country.

Policies accompanied by dollars, of course, as seems to have been the pattern about every other announcement throughout these last long months of electioneering.

It would be wonderful indeed to see an enhancement of settlement services for refugees in recognition of the particular barriers they face in their journey to integration, demonstrating our genuine understanding that "one size does not fit all," that some refugees will need more time, more resources, to settle in their new homeland.

While we're doing that, how about simplifying the whole landscape of settlement services - currently beleaguered by so many doors, so many criteria of eligibility, so many tiers, so many silos. You have to ask yourself -who really benefits.

And how about providing some bridging training opportunities for our overseas skilled migrants to help us meet the skills shortages Australia is experiencing in just about every industry?

And wouldn't it be nice to see some acknowledgement in our Constitution, that, our indigenous brothers and sisters aside, Australia is a country built by migrants, from the first Fleet onwards.

We are looking, but nothing so far. However hope springs eternal- an announcement by just one Party would do, as there seems to be considerable agreement between them on so many important areas of life.

On more mundane matters, this is my first report to you as Chairman of Northern Settlement Services Ltd, the name by which the Migrant Resource Centre has now been known since 16th January 2007, when it was officially registered with the authorities.

This has been the first year of the "brave new world" foreshadowed at our Silver Anniversary last June, following the loss of core funding from the Department of Immigration and Citizenship. It was an era that we, like all MRC's, faced with a little trepidation, understandably enough with the disappearance of that funding safety net which had been in place for 25 years.

But I am very pleased to say that any fears we may have had of losing our focus, or sliding into oblivion, were entirely groundless: 2007 has been a very good year for us, with strong growth in service delivery in the areas of aged care and family services, and very pleasing consolidation in our wide ranging settlement work.

With regard to the former we have been able to add Polish and Chinese clients through a successful bid under Community Aged Care Packages, and we will be better able to work with African refugee families through new funding from the federal Department of Family and Community Services and Indigenous Affairs (FACSIA), and a successful partnership with the Samaritans under the Early Intervention Program offered by the Department of Community Services. In terms of our settlement work, I am very pleased to report that the Department of Immigration and Citizenship has been very generous in its allocation to us under its Settlement Grants Program, and indeed we seemed to fare very well among all its recipient organisations throughout Australia. We are clearly doing something right.

So far from experiencing any losses, we are in fact making gains which consolidate our key role as a provider of services to refugees and migrants both in the Hunter and in the other areas where our work extends- the New England Region and the Central Coast of NSW.

Our greatest challenge has been to remember to answer to our new name!

Northern Settlement Services Ltd does not yet fall easily from our lips, and we are careful to add “formerly the MRC” just to remind our clients and colleagues (and ourselves!) of our metamorphosis.

We have been asked why the name change. The fact is that the brand name MRC disappeared when the core funding stopped; in truth we had outgrown it anyway through extending our services out of the Hunter. It made sense to us to find another name, better descriptive of our function and our footprint.

There is another very strategic reason for the name change. We are seeking to be recognised as a Public Benevolent Institution, with Gift Tax Deductibility, which would allow us to source project funding from alternative bodies, fundraise for charitable purposes, and last but not least, offer our dedicated staff more generous working conditions. The “MRC” entity is specifically precluded from such recognition by the ATO.

It is our sincere hope that our application will be favourably considered.

As always, I want to thank the dedicated team around me, the Board of Management whose unfailing support has, together and severally, sustained this agency for 26 years, and the amazing staff whose competence, energy, enthusiasm are surely “worth bottling.”

Henry Chan
Chairman



Director's Report

Violetta Walsh OAM

Every now and again organisations like ours undergo a period of adjustment and I look back on 2007 as such a period. While our name change, in itself, has not made any substantial difference – indeed, it is clear that the frenetic pace we had become accustomed to as an MRC has continued under our new banner. But we have taken the opportunity to streamline our internal workings in the interests of greater effectiveness. We have put in place a team based structure which we believe provides improved support and supervision to individual staff members, and stronger peer support for staff working in similar project areas. It also provides a very practical solution to the increasing complexity to the role of Agency Director, by sharing management responsibility with a number of team leaders.

I am pleased to report that these innovations have worked very well for us as an agency and more importantly have led to positive and beneficial outcomes for the people we serve. We have functioned with greater efficiency, and with a strengthened sense of team work and collaboration: in a nutshell, we have surpassed our goals, expanded our services and our geographic horizons' and balanced our books.

And in the new era we have entered, without the luxury of the previous safety net of core funding, this last outcome is very satisfying indeed. I would like to acknowledge at the outset the critical role played by our financial controller, Arlene Richards, in keeping us afloat in uncharted waters; she is almost dangerously indispensable to this organisation, and to all its funded projects.

As in most years, we have been successful in attracting project funding from various funding bodies which have allowed us to continue our service delivery to the particular target groups in the seamless and efficient way that achieves the right results. The Department of Immigration and Citizenship (DIAC) remains a major source of funding for a number of key settlement activities both in the Hunter, and in the north west of NSW, in the Tamworth and Armidale Regions, now with some added potential to outreach to Inverell. These are the areas where refugee settlement is occurring, and they are also a destination for skilled migrants, largely because of employment opportunities. Altogether the agency manages no fewer than 9 DIAC funded projects- ten, if we also include the Special Caseworker funding provided to us until July to look after one very high needs family. We have been most appreciative of DIAC's response to the needs of this family, and there is little doubt that this intervention has made an enormous difference to the well-being of the children.

The Hunter based African refugee work has continued apace, with our various African workers certainly kept busy. While the rate of new arrivals to the Region is not as great as it used to be, we still have a population of around 700 men, women and children from half a dozen or so African countries, with over half of these from Sudan. We are very mindful of the struggle that some of our refugees are having in making sense of their new world, and constantly amazed at their resilience and their optimism. If some seem to be having trouble adapting to this new and unfamiliar culture, we need to ask ourselves how would we fare in their shoes.

You will also see from the reports of the Aged Care Team that we have continued strongly in service delivery for this target population, which gives great satisfaction. This is a group who had been long overlooked during their young strong years in Australia, and it really is a case of catch up- and sadly, too late for many. But we value the state and federal funding that make our aged care possible, and look for any opportunity to “grow” this most rewarding and beneficial service delivery.

We value all the partnerships which have allowed us to strengthen and broaden our service delivery. Some of these partnerships are with government departments and are very longstanding; for example the Department of Community Services has been one of our funding bodies for close to 20 years, providing the resources for us to deliver welfare services to the truly disadvantaged among our communities, women and children, young people at risk and vulnerable families of all backgrounds.

Other equally important relationships have arisen from collegiate links based on sharing a common purpose, and are based on formal resource sharing arrangements such as the Migrant and Refugee Women’s Support Project which we partner so harmoniously with the Multicultural Neighbourhood Centre, and our membership of the Samaritans Foundation’s consortium which will allow us to better integrate Early Intervention services to CALD parents.

Other partnerships are less formal but very satisfying nonetheless. I include here just some examples-our long term relationship with the Community Refugee Support Group who work closely with our Volunteer Resource Worker to assist in settling our refugees; with Hamilton Public School (surely one of the most welcoming and most accessible institutions in this town) which hosts our after hours Homework Centre; with the Josephite Refugee Support Service, who can always be relied on to dispense compassionate but practical charity to those in need; with the Migrant Health Service with whom we hold the common philosophy of empowering people through education.

At the end of this long hard year we want to express our agency’s appreciation to all of those agencies, community based and government, who work with us to achieve better life outcomes for our clients.

No year at this place is complete without some farewells, as projects come to a close, or people need to move on. This year is no different. Paul, our peerless Volunteer Resource Worker is heading south, Devika, our beloved, funny Families First worker is off to Canberra. Clever Ibrahim, our Burundi worker is heading for bigger things having won a traineeship with Centrelink. But no harder goodbye than to Ann Dupree (CVS Coordinator) who has been a true warrior for the cause, whom I have had the joy of knowing for 25 years.

And there are Hellos too. Welcome to Marianne Mohr and Enza Di Stefano, mathematical whiz kids to assist with Finance; welcome to Silvia, our new receptionist, whose Spanish language skills will surely come in handy; to Mohamed Kamara, African Family worker; to Sarah, new Tongan welfare worker. I hope they enjoy their time here as much as I have.

As always I extend my heartfelt gratitude to the Board of “the good ship” NSS, for your guidance and direction at the helm, and to my staff whose capacity for hard work, yet good cheer, never fails to amaze me. You are truly legendary.

Violetta Walsh
Director

SPECIAL PROJECTS TEAM

**Ms Lulu Tantos
Deputy Director
Registered Migration Agent**

**Ms Irina Lupish
Registered Migration Agent**



Immigration Advice and Assistance Scheme

Lulu Tantos and Irina Lupish

Funded by the Department of Immigration and Citizenship

Northern Settlement Services Ltd (NSS) has been providing quality immigration advice and assistance to clients in Newcastle, the Hunter Region and its catchment area for over 15 years.

The service is provided by two highly trained and experienced Registered Migration Agents, Deputy Director Lulu Tantos and Irina Lupish.

As in previous years, the service has been provided to two distinct client groups:

- **IAAAS** (Immigration Advice & Application Assistance Scheme) eligible clients; and
- Fee paying clients

NSS is one of **23** DIAC (Department of Immigration and Citizenship) funded IAAAS providers around Australia offering free, professional migration advice and application assistance to eligible, needy immigration clients.

What counts as disadvantage? A 'Disadvantaged Person' is one who is in financial hardship and disadvantaged due to:

- non-English speaking background, youth, or other cultural issues such as gender barriers preventing assistance;
- illiteracy in main language of country of origin;
- remote location;
- physical or psychological disability, including from past torture or trauma; or
- physical or psychological harm resulting from family violence.

As part of our contractual obligations, outreach services have been conducted this year by Irina Lupish who has travelled widely across rural and regional NSW delivering a professional service to clients in Singleton, Inverell, Tamworth, Armidale, Coffs Harbour, Yamba, Orange and Lightning Ridge.

The scheme has provided the following assistance to **213** eligible clients and **3** community groups:

- Full Application Assistance
- Partial Application Assistance
- Immigration Advice: individual (face-to-face)
- Immigration Advice: individual (telephone)
- Community Information Sessions

In general, the past year has seen the Agents providing quality, professional services to more than **600** clients from over **59** different cultural backgrounds with clients from Australia, China, the Philippines, the Sudan, Thailand, Russia, India, Korea, the UK and Liberia featuring high in the statistics.

Over **1000** telephone enquiries were made and advice and assistance provided in the following areas:

- Skilled migration
- Partner Migration
- Temporary Business visas
- Other family migration including Parent, Remaining Relative and Carer visas
- Visitor visas
- Student visas
- Child Migration
- Humanitarian visas
- Citizenship
- Migration Review Tribunal

Throughout the year the service has been complemented by quarterly outreach visits to the office by experienced Officers from the DIAC Parramatta Office. This service has been invaluable in providing clients in our region with the opportunity to meet and discuss face- to- face their specific needs with a Departmental Officer. Initiated in 1996 as a result of the closure of the local immigration office it continues today and we are most grateful for the support and assistance the Officers from Parramatta provide to our staff and clients. We look forward to maintaining a close working relationship with them in the future, after all, “people are our business” too.

To Violetta, the Board of Management and to our colleagues thank you for your friendship, support and guidance throughout the year.

Lulu Tantos, Deputy Director/Registered Migration Agent
Irina Lupish, Registered Migration Agent

RURAL

TEAM

Mr Alex Burns
Rural Team Leader

Ms Miza Torlakovic
Hunter Outreach Worker

Ms Judith Roberts
SGP Worker New England
(Armidale)

Mr Home Phanoraj
SGP Worker New England
(Tamworth)

Ms Michelle Steele
Links to Learning Coordinator
(Tamworth)

Mr Chris Hudson
Links to Learning Coordinator
(Tamworth)



Rural Support Settlement Grants Program (SGP)
Rural Team Leader – Alex Burns
Funded by Department of Immigration and Citizenship

The Rural Team

The restructuring of the NSS workforce into teams means that one of my roles is now Team Leader for our rural projects. The Rural Team comprises three SGP projects, being the New England SGP, the Hunter Outreach SGP, the Rural Support SGP projects and the Tamworth Links to Learning project. During this year we have also seen a change from the old Community Settlement Services Scheme (CSSS) projects, as they became SGP projects and a move to new reporting processes including the recording of client casework through DIAC's Online Reporting (OSCAR).

Achievements of the Rural Team

The New England SGP project (consisting of Home Phanoraj and Judith Roberts) is described elsewhere but this year has seen the New England projects handle client work, mainly with refugees, in an area of some sensitivity following the outcry at the initial rejection of refugee settlement in the Tamworth area. Currently there are about **70** Africans living and working in the Tamworth area, which reflects a secondary movement of this group from other first settlement locations such as Sydney, Melbourne, Newcastle and Perth. While the large majority of the Africans are men from Sudanese backgrounds **5** families have also settled and single women mainly head these. While the men have sought work in the nearby meat works the family movement has been associated with a desire to settle in a rural area away from the pressures of a big city.

In Armidale and Inverell there are about **8** families and unlike Tamworth the settlement here is a primary settlement with families being supported by two Sanctuary settlement groups. The University of New England has also provided a healthy input of young people seeking to develop academic skills and careers and this has provided a positive interaction to the work here and is reflected in the success of the Armidale - Dumaresq Living in Harmony project called – **Together, Together**, to which we have given much support and direction. Other SGP work has been of two kinds, face-to-face casework and group work. The New England work has been excellent with four days devoted to Tamworth and Armidale each and a move to establish a one-day a week position at Inverell.

The Hunter SGP project, provided by Miza Torlakovic, is in many ways a classic example of the outreach that is undertaken by this organisation. Every week this project can be found in one of its Hunter locations, in Raymond Terrace or Salamander Bay, in Cessnock, Lake Macquarie and in Singleton meeting our responsibility to address client needs. In return there are very strong and supportive networks existing which we can call upon to assist with our clients and other work due to the dedication of this project from all Hunter Councils, health services, community welfare and court support services. The successful Refugee Week event at Singleton, the Harmony Day work at Muswellbrook and numerous client based consultations in Port Stephens and Cessnock have their base in the work of this project.

The **Links to Learning** project at Tamworth (manned by Michelle Steele) was established this year and initially focussed on addressing educational needs and future directions of the early school leavers from new arrival refugees and migrants and the Australian born children of migrant background parents. As a new project and with its

focus this project has started to come to fruition in September and October. Its base has now broadened to include the mainstream community and offers young people the opportunity to set future goals and address steps to meeting these. This is combined with the provision of several vocational courses to give the target group the opportunity of achieving success and to recognise each person's individual value. The work in establishing the project and moving it on has only succeeded because of emphasis of the project worker in not fading in an uncompromising environment.

The Rural Support SGP project covers the whole of the northern and western area of the DIAC (NSW) area of operation. This includes not only managing what happens in the NSS rural area but also providing mentoring in other areas where SGP workers are located including Lismore, Clarence Valley, Coffs Harbour, Manning Valley, Lightning Ridge, Dubbo, Orange and Bathurst. Table 1 indicates the ongoing level of support for SGP and CSSS projects over this year.

Table 1: An indication of the interaction the Rural Support project has with rural based CSSS/SGP projects November – July 2006-07

Projects and Contacts	Projects and Contacts
Central Coast 51	Hunter Outreach 118
Clarence Valley 78	NSS African 119
Lismore 53	Lightning Ridge 110
Bathurst 86	New England 246
Dubbo 36	Orange 57
Coffs Harbour St Vincent de Paul 62	African Youth 78
Anglicare (Coffs Harbour) 82	Manning Valley 60
Tamworth 225	Newcastle Women's NSS/MNC -88

Most interaction has been with the projects managed by the NSS and this form of support has included the provision of in house training on reporting and accountability, etc. Other work of the Rural Support project has included the provision of cultural awareness training support to SGP projects. This has included work with the New England projects, the Clarence Valley project, the Manning Valley project and the Lightning Ridge project, where three days was provided to Walgett Shire Council in this form of support.

Another area covered by this project included the convening of **3** of the rural based multicultural interagencies / networks. These were the North Coast Multicultural Network (**6**), the New England Multicultural Interagency (**4**) and the Newcastle Multicultural Interagency (**6**). Other interagency / forums were attended including the Central West Multicultural Interagency (**2**), the Mid-north coast Multicultural Network (**2**), the Hunter Rural Multicultural Network (**3**) as well as the Hunter Refugee Support Network (**4**).

Finally, the project participated in a range of government led meetings and forums convened by agencies such as DIAC, Centrelink, NSW DOCS, NSW DET, NSW DADHC, Hunter Water as well as several councils. Unfortunately, not as much of this work with other agencies was achievable due to the projects rural commitments as in former years.

Overall the Rural Support SGP project and the Rural Team Leader's role are very busy roles. The year has been rewarding and as a Team Leader it is great to work with the NSS staff in regional areas.

Alex Burns
Rural Support Worker
Rural Team Leader



Hunter Welfare Outreach Worker Settlement Grants Program (SGP)

Miza Torlakovic

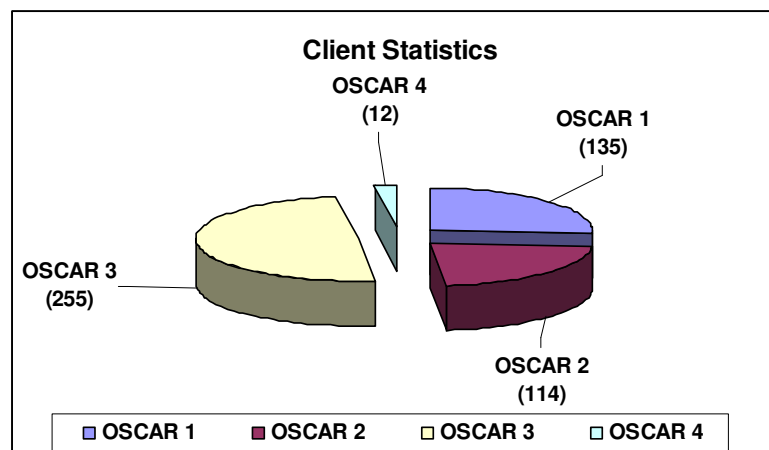
Funded by Department of Immigration and Citizenship

Background

In July of this year this project became a 1-year SGP project providing services to the DIAC target group in the Hunter, outside of Newcastle only. Thus it delivers casework services to Port Stephens, Lake Macquarie, Singleton, Maitland, Cessnock, Muswellbrook and the Upper Hunter.

The casework includes orientation to Australia and life skills to members of the target group – humanitarian entrants and migrants, including prospective marriage, provisional spouse, interdependency and skilled visa holders with low English proficiency in rural areas. Since last year a new statistical reporting format was developed by DIAC called OSCAR.

Diagram 1: Information and Referral Services January – October 2007



- **OSCAR 1** Long Contact (casework)
- **OSCAR 2** Subsequent casework
- **OSCAR 3** short contact
- **OSCAR 4** Group Sessions

Outreach

Currently there are 5 different outreach venues around Hunter where face-to-face services have been and continue to be provided. These locations are: Singleton, Cessnock, Charlestown (servicing southern Lake Macquarie) and Port Stephens, which has two outreach venues, Salamander Bay and Raymond Terrace. Diagram 1 lists the number of services provided by this project using the new OSCAR terminology.

I had some difficulty having an English language class for Singleton clients organized by WEA due to some concerns that both WEA and TAFE were running classes at the same time. In the end the students were told that WEA might not be able to continue English classes and all clients had to be referred to Singleton TAFE.

The project continues to advocate and work with services to promote the needs of the project target group. An example of this was my attendance at Singleton Council's meeting to find innovative ways to utilize the local mobile preschool. We identified areas of need, particularly those that would cater for families who are perceived as rural, disadvantaged and of CALD backgrounds. Another example of this work was the promotion of Harmony Day at Muswellbrook this year where the project supported the work of the Muswellbrook community to engage the whole community on the benefits of living in a harmonious society.

The project also facilitated cultural awareness for the Benevolent Society's Hunter work team. 20 Caseworkers were involved and the training was evaluated as worthwhile and rewarding. The Benevolent Society indicated that it would like to develop a partnership with our organization and it has been referred to the Director.

Other Work

This year the Refugee week celebration in Singleton took place on 27th June. This was in line with the move of Refugee Week from October to equate with World Refugee Day, which is celebrated on the 20th June. About **25** people attended the celebration held at Singleton Library. A shared luncheon, featuring different local cultures was organized in partnership with Singleton Council. It was a most successful day.

Singleton group work comprised several information sessions. These included presentations from an accredited Migration Agent, Job Network, the Tenancy Advice Service and **5** Sessions on Health issues, organized with the Multicultural Health Liaison officer. The Cessnock Group had a community consultation with Cessnock City Council, Family Support and Family InSight where the aim was to help the target group to understand what a community organization is and how these operate in Australia to provide services as well as how a person can participate in these types of organisations.

I attended Northern Settlement Services Planning meeting as well as a Rural Team meeting held for the team in Tamworth. The issues discussed were Oscar reporting, client access and housing. As part of this I visited the Guyra Tomato Farm, a huge glasshouse meeting with management and members of the NSS Rural Team and the farm's management where we talked about refugee and migrant employment opportunities.

Training

Attended the 2007 DIAC rural conference and met with all CSSS/SGP workers including all the NSS rural project workers. I also attended several training sessions such as several DV Forums, First Aid, Grief and Loss, Mental Health First Aid and Fire training,

During this year, the worker attended **2** NSS Staff meetings and **2** NSS caseworkers meetings and kept in touch with other services through a range of interagencies and networks -**2** at Singleton, **2** Upper Hunter Community Services at Scone and Muswellbrook, **1** at Cessnock, **3** at Port Stephens, a Port Stephen's planning meeting. In addition I continue to convene the Hunter Rural Multicultural Workers Network meetings (**3** this year) and I also attended **2** Multicultural Centrelink forums.

Miza Torlakovic
Hunter Outreach Worker

New England CSSS/SGP Project

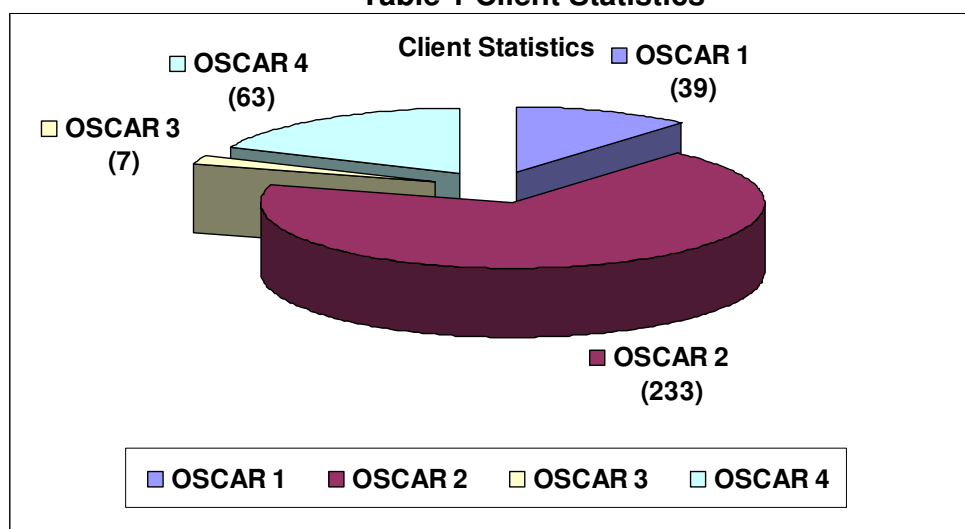
Funded by the Department of Immigration and Citizenship

Judith Roberts Settlement Support Worker

Judith Roberts & Kristin Teece commenced in January 2007 as locums for the CSSS project held by Leesa Moore. Both workers later resigned and Judith Roberts commenced as the Settlement Support Worker on the 09 July 2007. The CSSS project reverted to an SGP on 01 July 2007.

NSS Armidale continues to provide settlement information, referrals to other agencies where appropriate, community capacity building, service planning and development to new arrivals, including migrants and humanitarian entrants, and the dependents of skilled migrants.

Table 1 Client Statistics



- The high number of group sessions (OSCAR 4) reflects support work for Armidale-Dumaresq Council's Harmony project, Together, Together.

Client Services

The majority of clients are humanitarian entrants (202 visa holders) and those who were sponsored by Armidale Sanctuary Group. Young males and older women predominantly access the service. Particular issues for young men are employment, access to driving lessons, housing and access to ESL entitlements. This group has been well represented in the Together, Together Project with good outcomes. Other issues presenting were access to suitable childcare, family relationship breakdown and unfamiliarity with mainstream systems. Many clients also attend the ESL class at TAFE; these are a mix of Filipinos, Chinese, Sudanese and others. Students seek assistance or advice in an informal way and this raises awareness of the SGP.

The Tamworth Migrant Women's Support Group is a significant part of the SGP project. The needs of the group are met through informal means e.g. craft activities, social outings and group sessions. Changes to timetabling of AMEP classes have affected the group. Sudanese women have been attending regularly since the beginning of Term 3. Contact with the Women's Group has highlighted a number of areas that need to be addressed to provide settlement support to secondary settlers. A valuable partnership has been developed with Hunter New England Health to providing dietary sessions, a supermarket tour and a multicultural lunch. Outings such as picnics and a trip to a Girl Guide Camp at Kootingal have been organised during school holidays.

Where the settlement needs identified in relation to this group have required case work that goes beyond the group sessions it has been provided with the support of Home Phanoraj, SGP worker based in Tamworth. This group is also supported by the Tamworth Women's Refuge, volunteers and the Uniting Care Group led by Eddie Whitham.

Outreach to Inverell

I have made regular visits to clients in Inverell where possible and have liaised with the Inverell Sanctuary Group to provide settlement support to new arrivals in Inverell.

Information Sessions

Regular information sessions have been arranged for the target group as well as for service providers. A joint DIAC / NSS session was given to regional Police in February 2007. A Family Medicines session is to be given to a TAFE based group in November, while a session from the NSW Police has been postponed.

Meetings and Committee representation

The project is involved in a range of networking through attendance at various meetings including:

- New England Multicultural Interagency,
- Together, Together Steering Committee,
- New England Area Health Multicultural Access Committee,
- Community Drug Action Team,
- Armidale Interagency,
- Inverell Interagency,
- HNEH Community Mental Health Development Group,
- Sanctuary Armidale,
- HNEH Refugee Health Meetings,
- Armidale Dumaresq Council Resettlement Committee,
- DET New England Region Equity Committee-
- The project also works closely with the region's refugee nurse.

Together, Together Project funded by DIAC Living in Harmony Program

The SGP project works closely with Armidale Dumaresq Council' to support the training and ongoing work of their Together Together program, a public speaking initiative with participants from the migrant, refugee, indigenous and wider community. This has had rewarding outcomes for the participants.

Refugee Week

Refugee Week in Armidale was attended by about 150 people. The event was funded by Centrelink and the Refugee Council of Australia and brought people from Tamworth and Inverell to Armidale to participate. A display compiled by the SGP worker was held at Armidale Library featuring Dr Robin Jones' year in southern Sudan.

Training Attended

DIAC Rural Conference attended May 2007, Mental Health First Aid, First Aid, Introduction to Drug and Alcohol Sector TAFE, Sexual Assault Workshop, NSW Rape Crisis Centre.

This has been a challenging, but rewarding first year as a Settlement Support Worker and it has been enhanced by the rest of the Rural team, Alex Burns, Home Phanoraj, Michelle Steele and Miza Torlakovic.

Judith Roberts

SGP Worker (New England)



Tamworth / New England Settlement Grants Program
Home Phanoraj
Settlement Services Worker Tamworth
Funded by the Department of Immigration and Citizenship

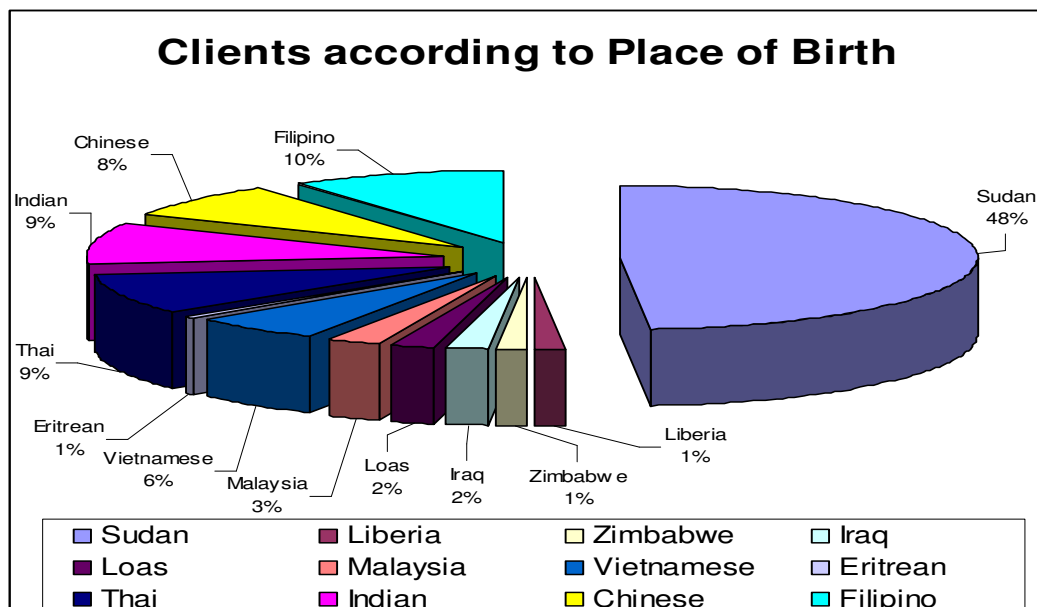
The Tamworth and New England Settlement Grant Project (SGP) has the task of Orientation, Developing Communities and Integration services to the eligible target group of refugees and migrants that settle in the Tamworth area.

The objective is to address the settlement issues of isolation, lack of supportive networks, and accessibility to the services, assist the community's development with a common purpose and promote a sense of self identity, determination, belonging and motivation to participate with the broader community. Through promotion, the project also raises the awareness among the mainstream service providers to become more responsive to the needs of the new arrivals.

In 2007, Tamworth SGP project had two components. The first component was the 2006 SGP program that served Tamworth separately from the rest of the New England area. From July this year Tamworth and the rest of the New England area are now being served by the one project – the New England Settlement Grants Program.

In this reporting period, the Tamworth work has dealt with **144** clients. **57%** of these were male while more than half were humanitarian entrants. Table 1 shows The background distribution of the clients that the Tamworth project has been working with in its day-to-day activities.

Table 1: Clients by Birthplace Background



Settlement issues

The refugee and migrant communities of Tamworth are diverse. However, the African community is identified, as a high need group. The settlement related issues range from accommodation, employment, English lessons, school enrolment, childcare, home tutoring, health checks, dental checks, driving without a licence, lack of access to driving training, jobs training, transportation, eviction, domestic violence & child welfare. However, among the secondary settlement (African) community, after finding jobs, it has proven to be very difficult to find accommodation of any condition to rent. As a result, a number have decided to look elsewhere for accommodation, even moving back to Sydney.

Employment opportunities

In Tamworth, 'Peel Valley' abattoir and the 'Biada' chicken processing plant are the two major sources of employment that attract the African community to the area. Currently, the majority of African men in the area are employed (97 percent) of the community. A small number of African men have travelled to Coffs Harbour to find seasonal harvesting work. Other migrant communities, such as women of Filipino background are employed more widely in chicken hatchery plants, nursing and age care. The Chinese, Thai, Indian, Lebanese and Vietnamese communities paid income is related to food and catering business and service stations.

Networking

Tamworth SGP has developed a good working relationship with volunteer groups and other service providers in the area. This includes organisations such as the local Uniting Care organisation, Church groups, Centrelink, Police, Childcare, Health, TAFE, Mental health Tamworth Community College and so on. The networking is maintained by attending interagency meetings and other interaction.

Information Sessions

The Tamworth project has developed a number of information sessions for the client group, which have involved numbers of other organisations. This has included 2 sessions with the new SGP project. In June we looked at Road Safety and Traffic Law as well as Car insurance. The guest speakers were Greg Birtle (Tamworth Police) and J.Lynch (Tamworth NRMA). In September we looked at housing issues with Tenancy Advocacy and the guest speaker was Annabel Doherty (Armidale Tenancy group)

Positive outlook

With the help of the Tamworth Community College and the Smith Family, home tutoring (English lessons) for the African clients will soon start. Tamworth SGP will assist Eddie Whitham (Uniting care) in coordination of this program. Tamworth Rotary organisation will provide driving instructors (volunteers) for clients.

Home Phanoraj
SGP Worker (New England)

Links To Learning

Michelle Steele

Funded by the Department of Education and Training

Introduction

Northern Settlement Services received the 2007 Tamworth Links To Learning Program. The initial contract was for **30** CALD early school leavers aged 14-24yrs.

Since commencement of the program a number of issues relating to meeting the target outcomes have been identified and addressed. Many of these issues relate to identifying and engaging with the target group. Participant numbers and actual hours are below those originally tendered which is expected considering the program was previously unknown to the Tamworth population. Our funding body is aware of these issues and has been extremely supportive in providing any form of assistance in meeting our outcomes. A need for the program to continue in the Tamworth area has been identified by the funding body during our mid year monitoring visit.

Much time and effort has been concentrated in building an awareness of the Links To Learning program and Northern Settlement Services within the Tamworth and Gunnedah areas. Referrals are beginning to be forwarded by local youth agencies, schools and employment services as a result.

At present an emphasis has been placed on building a stronger relationship with the Tamworth Centrelink office. Links To Learning is not currently seen as an approved Centrelink activity in the Tamworth area. This issue has minimized referrals as a majority of the target group is in receipt of Centrelink Youth Allowance.

Administration development has been a major focus over recent months with client file forms and teaching material being designed and integrated into the program.

Participation

- **4** enrolled with an extra **5** to commence in November, **9** in total.
- Actual hours are **278** hours
- **3** Sudanese enrolments have been unable to attend on a regular basis due to work commitments. **2** have recently travelled overseas for 2-3 months but both expressed interest in continuing in Links To Learning upon their return to Tamworth.
- One participant has come close to completion of the course. She has expressed interest in participation in the Hospitality program. Due to a recent critical incident while enrolled in L2L, further participation is currently under review. This incident has also affected transport for the participant from Gunnedah to Tamworth.

Referral Progress

- Referrals are primarily from local youth programs and schools. The Tamworth Youth Pathways program has referred **4** participants to Links To Learning in the recent week. **Youth Pathways have expressed an interest in providing finance for L2L to run an Anger Management Program.**
- Three local high schools have a number of referrals for L2L. At present principals and Deputy Principals are attempting to contact these students. Their participation at school has been very low or non existent and a number of Year 11 students have not maintained a standard high enough to continue onto Year 12.

Program direction from October 2007- December 2007

- Hospitality Course to be run on weekdays. The provider is Tamworth Vocational Education and Training Network.
- Computer course anticipated to be run on weekends to address barriers to L2L participation primarily by local refugees. The provider is Tamworth Community College.
- Each program is open to all early school leavers attend.

Employees

- A Coordinator/Facilitator replacement was arranged to commence the week beginning 2 October 2007 due to the current employee, Michelle Steele, preparing to commence on maternity leave. Unfortunately the offer was declined by the applicant the week prior. An advertisement for the position was forwarded to Joblink Plus, a local job network agency, and the Youth Interagency Mailing list.
- A number of resumes were viewed and the position has been now filled. Chris Hudson commenced employment on the week beginning 29th October 2007. Michelle will be providing support to the new Coordinator/Facilitator.

Conclusion

During 2007 the Links To learning program commenced in the Tamworth PCYC building. Much emphasis was placed on building an awareness of the program and Northern Settlement Services throughout the local community and appropriate referral agencies. This has proven successful through the improvement of participant referral numbers.

A number of obstacles in meeting targeted outcomes were identified and continue to be addressed. The target group has been opened to include early school leavers from the general population. A healthy and strong relationship has been established and continually strengthened with the local Department of Education. This proved very beneficial in gaining referrals through local schools. These referrals are young people who have recently disengaged from school.

A new coordinator/facilitator has been assigned to the position due to the previous employee commencing maternity leave.

Overall, extensive ground work has been carried out in developing and maintaining healthy relationships with local schools, Department of Education, youth agencies, training bodies, employment agencies and our funding body. Much time has also been devoted to developing teaching material and a professional document and administration format. A plan from October to December 2007 has been developed for the program with the focus on providing a hospitality program and an IT focused program. Many of the obstacles in meeting our expected outcomes have been identified and addressed with a continuance to do so.

Michelle Steele, Coordinator

AGED

CARE

TEAM

Ms Sue (Slavica) Hristov
CACP Coordinator
Aged Care Team Leader

Ms Lupe Fonua
CACP Coordinator

Ms Tima'Oto
CACP Coordinator

Ms Christine Follett
HRMS Coordinator

Ms Enza DiStefano
CVS Coordinator

Ms Sandra Wingrave
MSSS Central Coast
Senior Coordinator

Ms Olivia Fuente
MSSS Central Coast
Coordinator

Ms Sharlene Huber
MSSS Central Coast
Office Manager



COMMUNITY AGED CARE PACKAGES

**Funded by the Commonwealth Department of Health and Ageing
Sue (Slavica) Hristov, Tima 'Oto and Lupe Fonua.**

The Community Aged Care Packages (CACP) Program continues to go from strength to strength. The seventh year of operation saw a substantial increase in the number of packages and assistance that we are able to offer frail aged people from Non English Speaking Background living in the Hunter.

In the past year, we were successful in securing a further **17** packages to add to our existing **25**. In addition, excellent financial management has enabled us to offer two more places as unfunded extras - we are able to assist a total of **45** people with a wide range of home based support services that enables them to stay living at home as long as possible.

The significant increase in the number of packages funded by the government (both Multicultural and Chinese and Polish specific) which was a feature of the last funding round, is a welcome response to the growing needs of this vulnerable target group who might otherwise be at risk of premature entry to residential care.

TEAM STRUCTURE

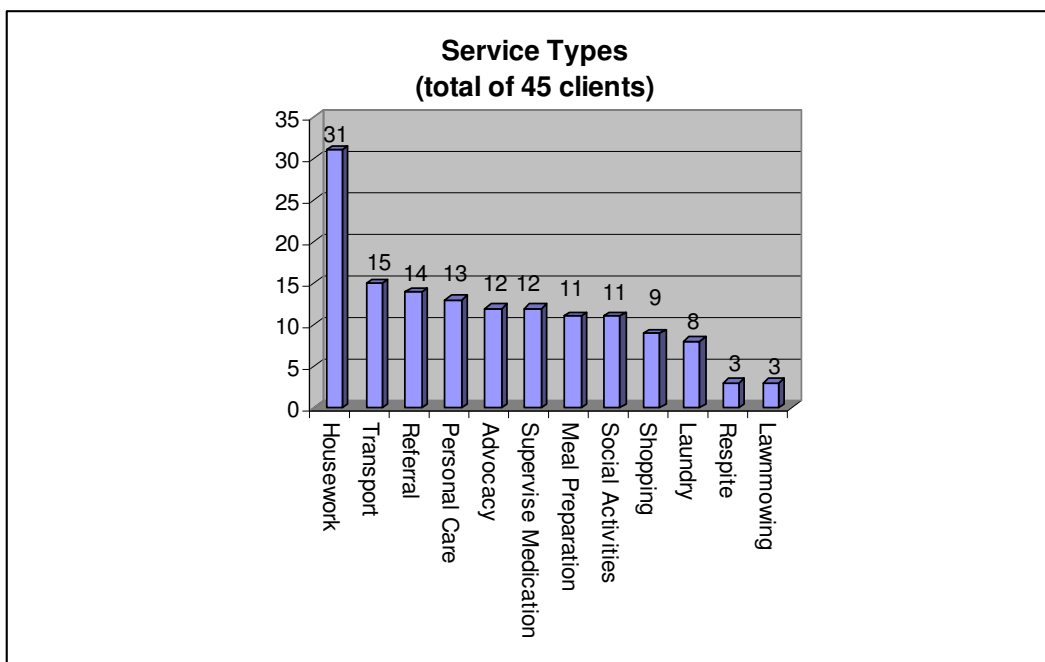
The Team Structure, with a designated Team Leader, introduced in the past year has proven useful in providing opportunities for people servicing a similar target group to share information and receive ongoing support as well as strengthening accountability mechanisms. Sue Hristov was appointed the Team Leader of the Aged Care Team (in addition to CACP Coordinator) which also includes the Community Visitors Scheme (CVS). Hunter Multicultural Respite Service and the Central Coast Multicultural Social Support Service

This year also saw the retirement of our much loved Anne Dupree, the Coordinator of the Community Visitors Scheme - her warm, caring, and sunny nature was a blessing to all who worked with her.

CARE RECIPIENT PROFILE

Care recipients come from a wide range of cultural and linguistic backgrounds: Italy, Greece, Poland, China, Ukraine, Germany, Sri Lanka, Macedonia, Slovenia.

- **7** Male
- **37** Female
- **22** with recipients living alone
- **23** have a live in carer
- **3** double packages- care required by both husband and wife
- **4** having Dementia.
- Age range **64** – to oldest at **96** years old



SERVICES PROVIDED

We provide about **175** hours of assistance per week - on average 4.1 hrs per care recipient (last year it was 3 hrs). Some require only 1-2 hrs per week while others require significantly more- with one as high as 14.5 hrs and a few others at 11, 10 and 9 hrs per week - last year we had only one who required 9 hours. While some of the higher need care recipients are on waiting lists for hostel and nursing home placement, we have a duty of care to continue to support them until other options are in place. Long waiting lists for residential as well as community based EACH programs mean that CACP is often providing significantly more hours of help than it was designed to do- prudent management will continue to be essential to ensure long term financial viability

MODEL OF SERVICE PROVISION

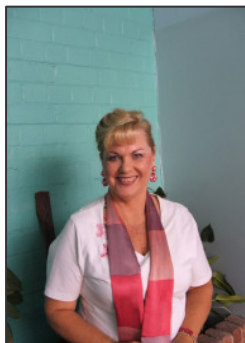
The flexibility of the brokerage model continues to serve our needs well: the Coordinators have responsibility for the significant case management component and care workers are contracted from reputable agencies for direct service provision. This model, with greater access to bilingual care workers, enables us to meet the needs of our target group in the most culturally and linguistically appropriate way.

CASE MANAGEMENT

Ongoing monitoring of care recipient needs is an essential feature of CACP and this enables us to quickly respond to changing care needs- either by increasing the assistance we can offer through care workers or referral and advocacy to a wide range community support services, such as Community nurses, Doctors, Specialists, Physiotherapists, Occupational therapists, podiatrists, diabetic clinics and respite services. Coordinators also contribute to case conferences prior to discharge from hospitals and offer more intensive assistance to care recipients and their families/carers at other times of personal or health related crisis situations, including the often very stressful time of making a decision for residential placement.

The coordination of services through the CACP continues to be both challenging and personally and professionally satisfying- especially in the past year with the almost doubling of the number of packages. The continued success of the CACP program would not have been possible without the continued support provided by management, fellow colleagues as well as the excellent relationships formed with service providers, which has enabled us to make a significant impact on improving the quality of life for our care recipients.

Sue (Slavica) Hristov, CACP Coordinator, Aged Care Team Leader
Lupe Fonua and Tima 'Oto CACP Coordinators



HUNTER MULTICULTURAL RESPITE SERVICE

Funded by Department of Ageing, Disability & Homecare (DADHC) through Home & Community Care Program (HACC).

Hunter Multicultural Respite Service (HMRS) provides respite care for frail older people or people with dementia from non-English speaking backgrounds experiencing difficulty in attending Day Care Centres. The service provides a culturally appropriate worker to assist with care of clients at Day Care Centres to sustain the placement at Day Care and to provide the carers some respite.

Model of Service Provision

HMRS is staffed by one part-time coordinator (3 days per week). Direct care services are provided on a brokerage model. The brokerage model has proven to be efficient and effective, as it enables the HRMS to have a wider pool of workers to choose from and therefore to better meet the cultural and linguistic needs of particular clients as well as negating any insurance issues.

Services provided

Throughout 2007, 38 clients have had weekly services of between 2-8 hours per week, including transport for 7 clients. Three clients attend more than one Day Care Centre. A total of 16 new clients have commenced services in 2007 and 8 clients have either died throughout the year or ceased service mainly due to placement into permanent residential care. All clients have been formally assessed initially and reviewed after 6 months of service. There are no clients on waiting list and every client referred has been offered service.

In addition over 35 carers have been supported by direct service provision

Day Care Centre	No of clients per Day Care as of 30/10/2007
Greek Day Care	5
Holy Apostles Day Care	3
Macedonian Day Care	2
Italian Day Care	8
Polish Day Care	5
Maitland Multicultural Friendship Group	2
Alkira Dementia Centre, Toronto	3
Wattle Grove Dementia Day Care	1
Allawah Day Centre, Wallsend	3
East Lake Macquarie Dementia service	1
Southlakes Day Care, Morisset	2
TOTAL	35

Administration

- A DADHC grant of \$5000 was used to purchase ethno-specific and mobility resources such as wheelchairs, walking frames.
- New agreements and risk assessments of Day care Centres were signed off throughout the year to follow up from DADHC action plan.
- MDS database was updated in the new HADS format and data successfully transferred
- MDS statistics compiled and sent to DADHC quarterly.

Multicultural Dementia Support Group

The service coordinates the monthly meeting of the group at NSS on the third Wednesday of the month. Throughout the year we have had speakers and information sessions to assist and support carers of migrants with dementia from the following organisations: Commonwealth Carer Respite Centre, 'Petal Back' Design clothing as well as a two bus trips: a shopping outing to Tuggerah Centre and a very enjoyable outing to Hunter Valley Gardens for Carers Week.

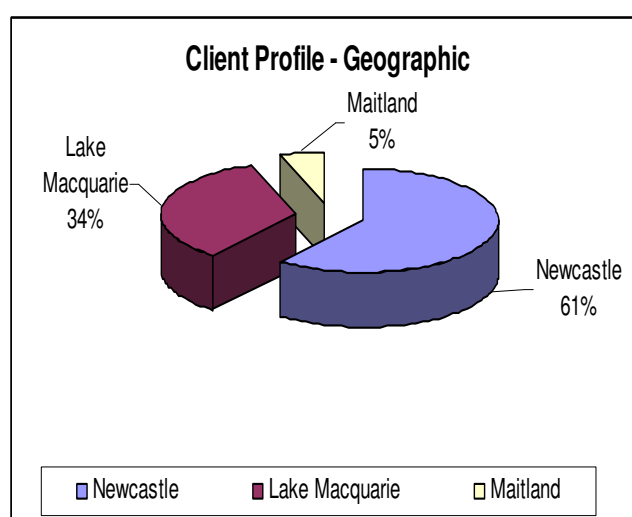
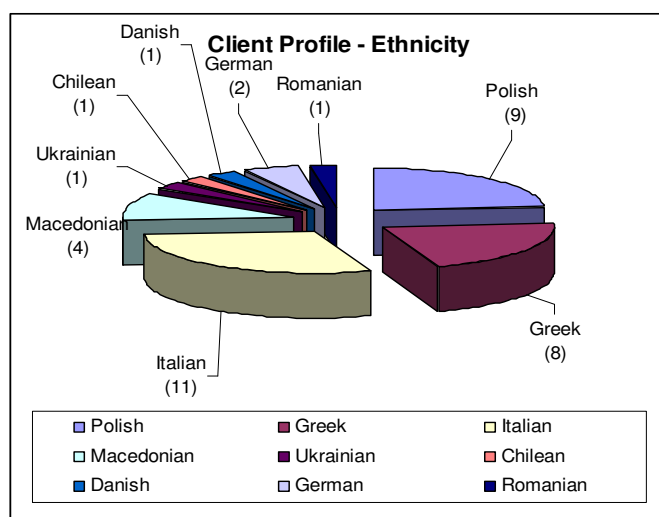
Training / conferences attended throughout the year include:

- MDS Training, Tighes Hill TAFE, 27 February 2007
- MDS HADS Training, Newcastle University, 27 March 2007
- Services Supporting Carers, Carers NSW, Charlestown, 27 April 2007
- Experiencing Dementia Workshop, Alzheimer's Australia, Singleton, 30 April 2007
- ONI Training (new referral Tool), Wallsend, 24 May 2007
- Dementia Symposium, DADHC, Newcastle, 5 June 2007
- Mental Health First Aid Training, NSCCAHS Mental Health Team, Niagara Park, 18 & 25 May 2007
- Fire Training, Northern Settlement Services, 17 July 2007
- Interpreting Pilot Training, South West Sydney Health Service, 24 July 2007

Meetings attended on a regular basis include:

- Quality and Team meetings, NSS Aged Care Services
- Hunter Ethnic Aged Services Network
- HACC services and Community Services Network quarterly meetings
- Dementia Interagency meetings
- Upper Hunter Interagency

Client characteristics						
Gender		Age			Client condition	
Male	Female	60-75	75-89	90+	Dementia	Frail Aged
14	24	3	25	10	16	22



I would like to thank the management and my colleagues at NSS for their assistance and support, which has enabled the service to consolidate and build successfully throughout 2007.

Christine Follett
Coordinator



COMMUNITY VISITORS SCHEME

Funded by the Commonwealth Department of Health and Ageing

Enza Di Stefano

I would like to take this opportunity to introduce myself as the new Northern Settlement Services Community Visitors Scheme (CVS) co-ordinator. I commenced in this position on 3rd October 2007 on the retirement of Johanna (Ann) Dupree. I have been fortunate to have worked with Ann previously and to have wonderful volunteers to work with and I am looking forward to continuing the great success of the CVS Program in the Lower Hunter.

Northern Settlement Services' CVS continues to provide a highly effective, efficient and valued program to residents from CALD backgrounds needing a visitor in Lower Hunter nursing homes. Over **970** face-to-face visits were conducted in the past twelve months and the distances travelled by these visitors in providing their service totalled approximately **17,000** kilometres. Over the last twelve months **17** Nursing Homes have been visited with a total of **1,042** visits to 34 residents.

Community Visitor Recruitment and Turnover:

Recruitment of volunteers is an on-going process and during the year **18** volunteers were available, with **15** actively involved. **3** volunteers have resigned during the year due either to ill health, advanced age or family commitments, and since my appointment **3** new volunteers have commenced orientation and the Police Check procedure.

Levels of metropolitan, rural and remote activity.

The NSS Community Visitor Scheme covers the 4 LGA's of Newcastle, Lake Macquarie, Port Stephens and Maitland. A couple of these have a rural / metropolitan interface. The CVS occasionally receives referrals and requests from the Upper Hunter LGA's, which we have not been able to accommodate so far. The majority of available visitors live in metropolitan areas and are not able or willing to travel the considerable distances involved in such a geographically dispersed area as the Upper Hunter.

In some instances a visitor may be found in the relevant area, but the visitor is not from the same cultural and / or linguistic background. Matching residents with visitors of similar cultural and linguistic backgrounds is especially important to our target group as people often revert to their native language with advancing years and the onset of Dementia. CVS will endeavour to make continuing efforts to address the needs of residents in the Upper Hunter depending on the availability of suitable visitors.

Number of Nursing Homes Visited by LGA 2006-2007

LGA	Nursing Homes currently being visited	Currently Stopped Visitation	Total of Nursing Homes Visited
Newcastle	7	1	8
Lake Macquarie	3	1	4
Port Stephens	3		3
Maitland	2		2
Totals:	15	2	17

- Cessation of visitor activity at these nursing homes was due to one volunteer resigning due to family commitments another who resigned due to ill health.

Orientation Activities:

Orientation/ training/ support activities conducted in the last twelve months focused on organising two major outings for visitors: one at Christmas and one in Volunteer Week. This was a good opportunity to acknowledge and in a small way reward volunteers for the invaluable contribution they make to the quality of life of the residents they visit. Orientation for current and future visitors will now include a Police Check. Visitors recently attended a workshop on "Manual Handling for Volunteers" which reaffirmed the importance of looking after oneself as well as the resident.

Information and Promotion Activities:

The most successful promotion activities have proven to be the extensive, longstanding contacts and working relationships with local ethnic communities/organisations and networks servicing a similar target group. These will remain the main focus of future promotion activities with a publicity campaign on a local community radio station which broadcasts in a dozen different languages already planned. In addition I will be doing mail outs to residential facilities to raise awareness of what we can offer residents and seeking referrals from CALD residents who might benefit from a visitor.

Benefits of the Scheme:

- Visitors play an integral role in easing the social and cultural isolation experienced by many residents who may not have family living close by and whose extended support networks were left behind when they migrated.
- Visitors from a similar cultural background provide an opportunity for residents to maintain a link to the community through sharing of news and current activities in the community.
- The Scheme as it currently operates under the auspice of NSS is able to provide support to people from a wide range of cultural/linguistic backgrounds despite the demographic reality of an ageing population – most of the current visitors are drawn from communities which settled here post World War 2. This diminishing pool of visitors has necessitated adopting a useful and necessary strategy of a number of visitors seeing more than one resident in the same facility and often in different facilities. Adopting this strategy has resulted in the program being able to provide support to a larger number of residents.

Satisfaction with the Service Provided:

CVS continues to receive feedback from residents and staff of residential facilities which indicates that the service is welcomed and appreciated and those residents from culturally and linguistically diverse backgrounds would experience a greater degree of social isolation without the support and friendship provided by community visitors.

Relationship with the Department of Health and Ageing:

Feedback from the Department continues to be very positive. At a Regional CVS Network Meeting held on 22nd October I was able to obtain "The Community Visitors Scheme Handbook" translated into five community languages from the Department CVS Consultant Mr Sam Moresi. These publications will be distributed to prospective visitors and will facilitate their understanding of the Scheme. At this meeting, Mr Moresi made a special presentation from the Department of Health and Ageing to Ann Dupree, in recognition of the outstanding work and contribution made by her.

Ann will be sorely missed by her work colleagues, residents and wonderful volunteers she has befriended over the past 14 years as the inaugural co-ordinator of the NSS Community Visitors Scheme.

Enza DiStefano
CVS Coordinator



**Multicultural Social Support Service Central Coast
Funded by the Department of Ageing, Disability & Home
Care (DADHC) – Home & Community Care (HACC)
Program.**

Senior Coordinator: Sandra Wingrave

Coordinator: Olivia Fuente

Office Manager: Sharlene Huber

The Multicultural Social Support Service (MSSS) has now been operating for two and a half years. MSSS supports CALD people in Wyong & Gosford LGAs who are: frail aged, younger people with a disability, and carers.

MODEL OF SERVICE PROVISION

Volunteers provide social support to clients and carers of the service which includes: home visits, telephone calls, taking clients: shopping, banking, to medical appointments etc and supporting Clients to attend outings and events.

ADMINISTRATION

The following administration tasks have been undertaken throughout the year:

- Action Plan development for the five outstanding items that required follow-up as an outcome of the DADHC Monitoring Review.
- The MSSS Policy and Procedures has recently been reviewed and edited.
- Monthly media releases to inform the community about the MSSS and also for the purpose of recruiting new Volunteers. 86 Volunteer application kits were sent out as a result of the advertising. 49% of Volunteer applicants found out about the service through advertising in local commercial newspapers and this continues to be the most successful means of attracting new Volunteers.
- Distribution of service brochures and relevant information.
- The design and distribution of the Volunteer Newsletter.
- Relevant OH&S assessments and processes were carried out as scheduled.
- Processing of Volunteer reimbursements, Client service fees and petty cash balancing.

VOLUNTEER MAINTENANCE & DEVELOPMENT

To date, the service has 33 registered volunteers, 29 of whom are actively involved with clients, and of which, 53% speak languages other than English

MSSS organised two training days during 2007: July and October which included some entertainment, fun, and supervision & support meetings, as well as training in cross cultural awareness, and manual handling. Other HACC Training offered to our volunteers included Random Acts of Counselling, Boundaries, Self Care, Introduction to Challenging Behaviour, Dementia Awareness, and Senior First Aid. We are encouraged by the high participation rate of our volunteers in undertaking training.

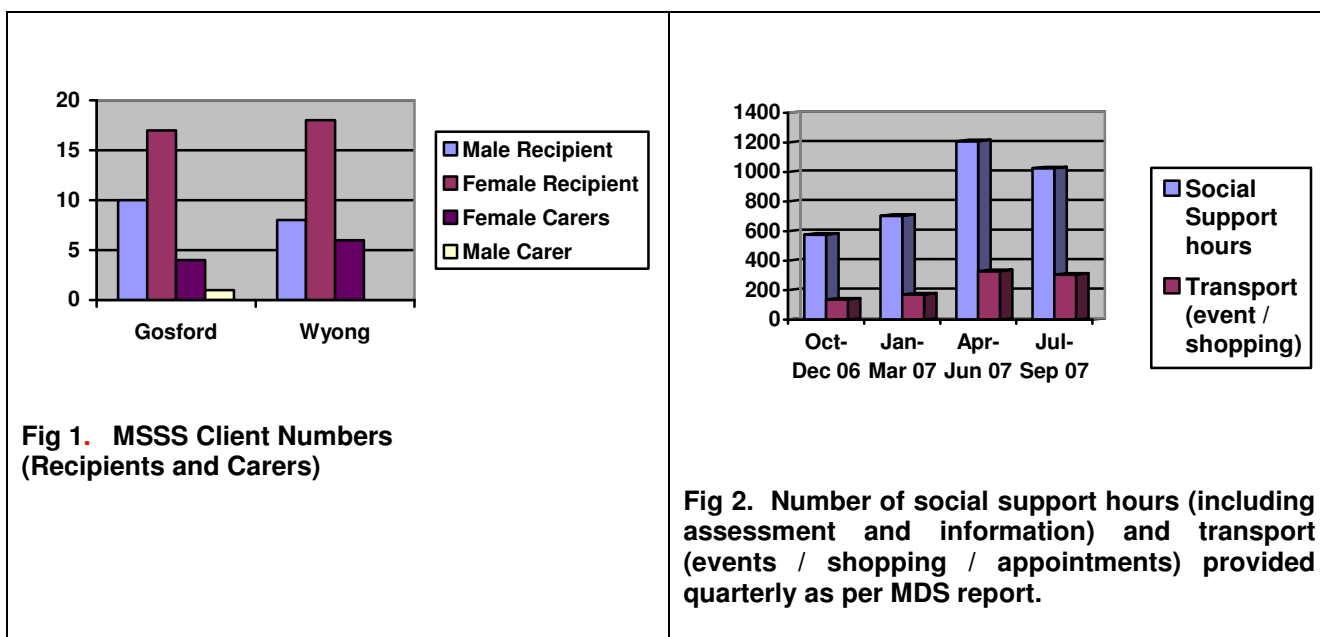
We expressed our appreciation to our volunteers by inviting them to a social day at Breakaway Lodge in May, and also to a luncheon in November.

CLIENT/CARER PROFILE

We continue to receive referrals for clients from ACAT, Community Nursing, local hospitals, Legacy, word of mouth, and from our advertising and promotions. Fig. 1 shows the distribution of Clients in the Wyong and Gosford LGA's.

Nationalities represented within our Client/Carer service include Chinese, Polish, Maltese, Singaporean, Filipino, Spanish, Greek, Italian, German, Croatian, Finnish, Hungarian, Serbian, Dutch, Russian, Fijian, Egyptian, Romanian.

Fig. 2, the large increase of social support hours in Jan – Mar 07 figures was due to client outings for both Wyong and Gosford LGAs, while the decline in the next quarter was due to cessation of regular services to a few clients in Wyong LGA.



PROMOTION

We take every opportunity to promote our Service. During 2007 MSSS acquired a banner which is portable and easy to erect, and also an easel and display board for photographs. Promotions included:-

Australia Day
International Women's Day Health Forum
Impact of Ageing for CALD people
Mental Health Expo
Multicultural Services Information Expo

Harmony Day events
Seniors' Week Forum
Refugee Forum
Connecting women in Gosford
Carers' Service Expo

We have had exposure in local newspapers and The Senior, including editorial and photographs. MSSS also featured on Central Coast Community Radio – The Bridge Program.

We have spoken to students at local TAFE colleges, and women at CWA meetings, as well as culture specific social groups, and local hospital discharge planners/social workers. A new volunteer specific brochure has been produced and widely distributed.

Sandra Wingrave & Olivia Fuente Coordinators
Sharlene Huber Office Manager

AFRICAN TEAM

**Mr Michael Adderley
African Team Leader**

**Mr Simon Majur Pabek
African Support Worker**

**Mr Marial Fieg
African Youth Worker**

**Mr Zach Ekandi
African Family Worker**

**Mr Mohamed Kamara
African Family Worker**

**Ms Zenaida Edmunds
African Family Worker**

**Ms Joselyne Ntahomvukiye
African Family Worker**

**Mr Paul Sidebottom (resigned)
Mr Michael Freund
Volunteer Resource Worker**



New Land New Laws Crime Prevention Project
Funded by the Federal Attorney Generals Department
Michael Adderley

The New Land New Laws project was established to assist African refugees with understanding their rights and responsibilities under Australian laws. The project began on the 3 January 2006 and was completed on the 30 June 2007. As the first 6 months of the project were covered in last years Annual Report, this report will cover the final 12 months of the project (1 July 2006 – 30 June 2007).

The four main objectives of the project were;

- To promote understanding of, and compliance with, the law and expectations of living in Australia among newly-arrived African refugees.
- To develop self help mechanisms and strategies among African refugee communities to reduce incidences of crime among members and allay community safety fears.
- To develop interventionist strategies aimed at young refugees at risk of offending and/or behaving inappropriately.
- To raise awareness in the mainstream community of the profile of the African refugee communities with a view to dispelling negative myths and misconceptions.

The project was very useful for determining the extent of law and order issues within Newcastle's African refugee population. The project showed that members of the African refugee community were not overrepresented in crime statistics however there were a number of issues, such as domestic violence, traffic offences and youth crime and anti-social behaviour, which did exist and presented unique challenges in addressing them.

Many law and order related matters stemmed from settlement issues where individuals had difficulties adjusting to the Australian customs and practices. This included such issues as the roles of women in Australian society, the reduction in the role of men as breadwinners for the family, newfound freedoms embraced by teenagers and the desire to own and drive a motor vehicle. Therefore the ability to address these issues was often complex and met with many challenges. For example, it was difficult for many in the community to accept that the perpetrators of domestic violence were to blame, with the victim often being blamed for abandoning their customs therefore forcing the offender to take the action that they did. These views reached all levels of the community making strategies such as empowering elders and using them to assist in changing attitudes of the wider refugee community difficult.

Other issues, such as unlicensed driving, will require not only ongoing education but greater financial resources. 'Learner' drivers are required to attain 120 hours of supervised driving experience before gaining their 'Ps'. This requirement is currently very difficult for African refugees to meet due to a lack of access to drivers with full licences willing to teach others and the cost of professional driving lessons.

An analysis of crime statistics at the conclusion of the project failed to determine any significant increase or decrease in crime figures as these were generally low and no pattern could be identified.

In summary the project was very useful in providing a range of law enforcement and legal agencies to understand the issues impacting on members of the African refugee community. Clear and effective procedures have been established between police, courts, Northern Settlement Services and the African refugee communities to improve communication and relations between all involved. This project has also seen Northern Settlement Services recognised by many local law enforcement and legal organisations as the lead agency in identifying and assisting with law and order issues within refugee and other emerging communities.

I would like to give special thanks to the Waratah and Newcastle Police commands for their support of this project and the continuing cooperation working with the African refugee community despite the completion of this project.

Tenancy Awareness Rights (for the Dinka Community)
Funded by the NSW Office of Fair Trading
Michael Adderley & Tima 'Oto

The Think Smart Tenancy Project titled “***Tenancy Awareness Rights Project***” commenced on the 31st August 2006 and concluded on the 30th June 2007.

The objectives of the project were to:

- Develop tenancy awareness through conducting information sessions in small groups among the Dinka families on the following issues:
- Renting rights and responsibilities
- Greater confidence in dealing with landlords and real estate agents
- Maintaining harmonious relationships with neighbours
- Accessing mainstream tenancy advisory services
- Deliver tenancy information awareness to the Dinka tribe in a linguistically and culturally appropriate way
- Deliver information through the medium of radio to capture those with low literacy levels
- Develop a DVD with graphics on tenancy maintenance using a Dinka language voiceover.

There are approximately **60** Dinka families residing in the Newcastle/Hunter region. In the period that the project ran, **4** sessions were held. A total of **32** people attended these sessions which resulted in approximately **50%** of all Dinka households being given tenancy information. These sessions were presented by both Real Estate agents and the Manager of the Office of Fair Trading (Newcastle). NSS continues to give tenancy support to all members of the African refugee community through its current African community projects.

Since the completion of this project there has been a noticeable decrease in the number of complaints (such as for rent arrears and untidiness of properties) from real estate agents and landlords about African refugee tenants. Despite this, difficulties are still being experienced in finding suitable affordable housing for African refugee families, especially for large families.

At the time the project was running, Newcastle did not have a radio program for African communities. From October 2007, NSS has been broadcasting weekly radio programs on 2NUR-FM. Tenancy information will continue be communicated to the African refugee community through this radio program.



Community Soccer Project
Funded through the Community Development
Support Expenditure Scheme
Michael Adderley & Mohamed Kamara

In early 2006 several young men from Newcastle's African refugee community wanted to establish a soccer team to occupy their time keep up their fitness levels and possibly play against other teams from Newcastle and Sydney. These men approached Northern Settlement Services to seek help in identifying a suitable training venue and assist with any funding they may need. Northern Settlement Services applied for funding through the Community Development Support Expenditure (CDSE) program and subsequently gained funding through the generous support from the Newcastle Western Suburbs Leagues Club, Hexham Bowling Club and Beresfield Bowling Club.

To meet the requirements of the CDSE grant, the program's aim was not to form an "African" soccer team but to have a program that will assist members of Newcastle's African refugee community to integrate with the wider community through involvement in a program they are truly passionate about. In fact, the team already has a number of non-African players who regularly attend team training.

With over 30 players regularly attending training 3 nights per week, the team was keen to play against other teams to test their skills. However this has not been without its challenges. The main challenge being trying to secure an adequate soccer ground in the middle of the Australian cricket season (something those from non-cricket playing African nations find hard to understand). As a result, a number of matches have been postponed due to the lack of suitable facilities. Despite this the team has played a number of 'friendlies' against teams from Newcastle University and several African teams from Sydney.

When the regular soccer season began in April 2007 this program assisted all willing players to join regular Newcastle soccer teams, with great interest and support shown by a number of local soccer clubs to embrace the African players. Integration through a sporting program has been an effective way of developing English language skills and making the contacts with members of the wider community which may lead to employment and social opportunities.

It is hoped that the involvement of African refugees in mainstream soccer teams will continue despite this project coming to an end however issues such as a lack of finances will always be a barrier for many refugees to participate in main stream sporting activities in Australia.

With the assistance of the CDSE funding and Newcastle TAFE, Tighes Hill, soccer goal posts have been purchased and are to be in place permanently for members of the African community and others to train and play soccer all year round.

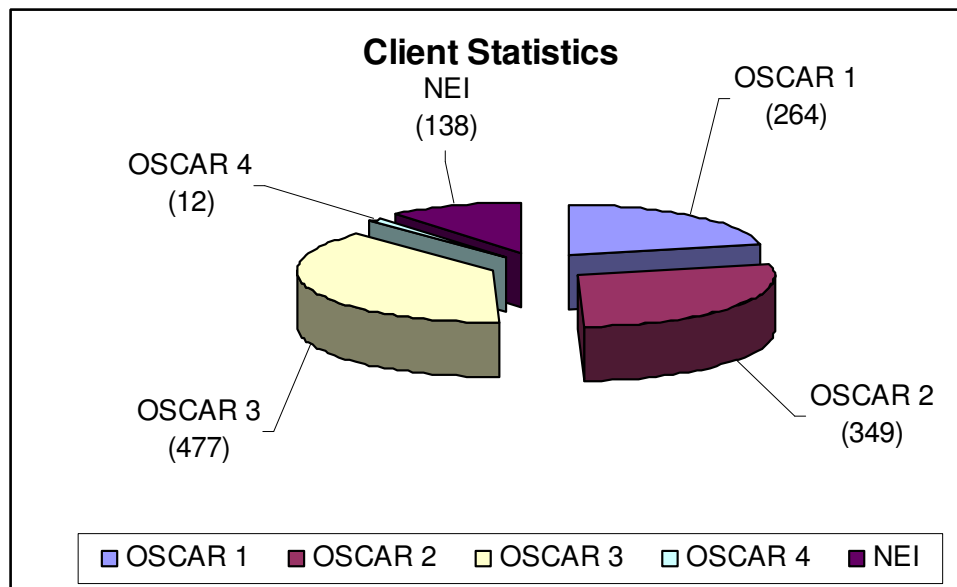
Michael Adderley
Project Officer, African Team Leader



Sudanese & African Communities Support Worker (SGP)

Funded by Department of Immigration & Citizenship
Simon Majur Pabek

The project offers referral and casework information to refugees, special humanitarian entrants, agencies and services providers in the Newcastle and Lower Hunter Region.



Client Contacts Services from November 2006 to October 2007

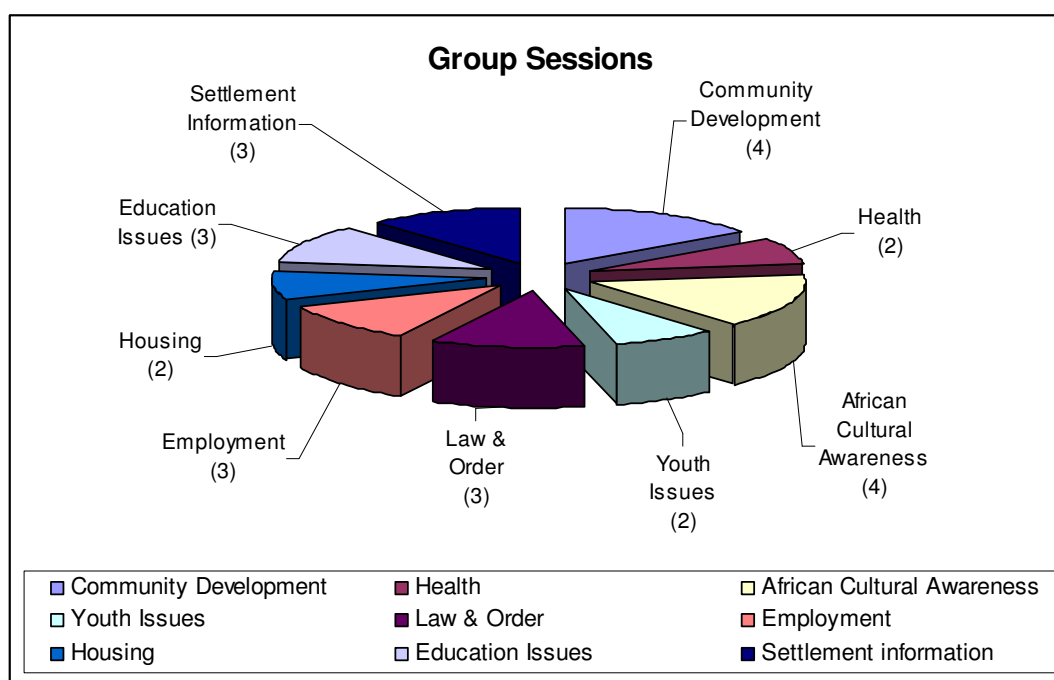
OSCAR 1	First Long Contact (Casework)
OSCAR 2	Subsequent to First Long Contact (Subsequent casework)
OSCAR 3	Short Contact
OSCAR 4	Group Sessions
NEI	Not elsewhere included.

In the 12 month period as shown above the African Support worker (SGP) provided **1240** occasions of services to African clients, services providers, government agencies including volunteers and other members of the wider Australian community assisting newly arrived refugees, **264** occasions of service as a first long (OSCAR 1) contact, **349** occasions as subsequent to first contact (OSCAR 2), **477** occasions of short client contact (OSCAR 3), 12 group sessions (OSCAR 4) and **138** other occasions of service.

All those services were delivered to clients by telephone or as face to face services. The number of clients receiving services varied over the year from a high in March, July and August and lows in May and September. Clients are indicating that they are now more confident in visiting services on their own due to the familiarity of the African communities' members with the local area and services provided.

Group Work

In this year **26** information sessions were organized around Newcastle and the Lower Hunter region as well as one in Tamworth to specific groups of clients and agencies and these include **12** sessions to target groups and **14** sessions to agencies and services providers in different areas.



Sessions to target group, agencies and services providers

All sessions were well attended by service providers, government agencies and members of the target group.

Other Work:

From October 22nd one day of service is being provided at Metford TAFE every Monday. This will continue for the duration of project. Some service providers in the Maitland area have been informed about this service e.g. Hunter New England Health, AMEP, Police and Maitland Council.

Two African Young Girls Health sessions have been organized at Northern Settlement Services with the Family Planning office in Darby Street under the title "Sexual Education". The sessions were organized with partnership between Northern Settlement Services and Family Planning.

The project has been working closely with consultants from JobQuest to assist African students at high school (Year 11 & 12) in pathways to education. Two sessions were organized at JobQuest entitled "Culture and Education Background in some African countries". Over 13 consultants attended the two sessions. The new Hunter African Communities Council was established and the interim committee that was formed will continue until an election takes place in a few months.

Simon Majur Pabek
African Welfare Worker



African Youth Worker

Marial Fieg

Funded by Department of Immigration & Citizenship

This program started on the 1st July 2005. The aim of the project is to identify and address the issues of young people of African background living in Newcastle with outreach to Lake Macquarie and Maitland. The target group are people aged from 12-24 years.

The position aims to increase youth participation in existing services and to develop responses to cover gaps in youth services provision, especially to small and emerging communities.

The main work of the project is to provide support, information, referral, casework, service planning and development and capacity building to assist African young people in their settlement. The project also participates in local and regional youth and community networks.

Recreational Activities

Similar to last years activities there has been a focus on encouraging African youth to participate in recreational activities to assist in their integration into life in Australia, improve their self-confidence and develop their life-skills. In the past 12 months I have developed or supported a range of activities for African youth. These include:

- Weekly group activities at Newcastle Police Citizen's Youth Club (PCYC) which includes sporting, video games, and social activities. This is run in partnership with Samaritans Foundation, Newcastle Basketball Association, PCYC and NSS.
- African soccer team and supporting youths to participate in mainstream soccer activities.
- Sudanese youth dancing group.
- West African youth dancing group.
- Surf Lifesaving and Surf Awareness program conducted in partnership with Newcastle Council City, San Clemente Catholic school and Lambton High School
- Four day Aussie bush camping in partnership with STARTTS Recreation officer at Lake Keepit Sport and Recreation Centre.
- Establishment of African youth dancing group in partnership with Multicultural Neighbourhood Centre youth worker. This was developed between July to September 2007 and includes Sudanese youth dancing group and West African dancing group.

Youth employment

Unemployment is a huge issue for all African communities and especially for young African people in the Hunter region, more so than elsewhere in Australia. This impacts greatly on young people, especially Sudanese young people who are at a great social and economic disadvantage. This project is working hard with other African projects at Northern Settlement Services to raise awareness and knowledge of employment, vocational and educational needs of refugee African young people by running many sessions in different areas including schools, TAFE, Job Network providers and through various youth and refugee networks. Lack of language skills, education and networks in the local Newcastle community and lack of motivation by

some individuals continue to be major barriers to African youths gaining full or part-time employment.

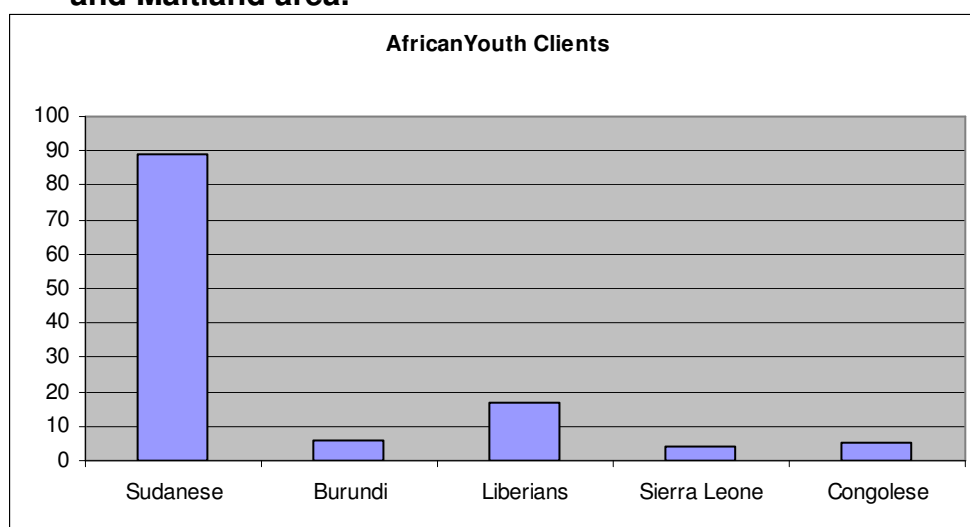
Education & Training

Large numbers of young Africans are enrolled in various high schools, primary schools and TAFES around the Newcastle and Hunter Region. Since the project started in 2005 the African Youth project has been working with schools and parents for the purpose of integrating the newly arrived young people into the mainstream community. I have been involved in regular meetings in schools with the parents and school staff as well as running sessions for schools and young Africans on cultural awareness and educational pathways. The purpose of these activities has been to build the confidence of youths and to break down the barriers between African parents and schools. I have also assisted agencies such as schools and the police to overcome language and communication barriers between African young people and these agencies and other young Australian people.

Skill Development

I attended the three day Rural CSSS workers conference in May, which provided training for CSSS workers working in regional and rural NSW. I am also doing a community worker course at TAFE (Certificate IV). I have been a guest speaker at the Australia Refugee Council youth teleconference in March 2007 and at the Newcastle RYDON youth conference in July 2007.

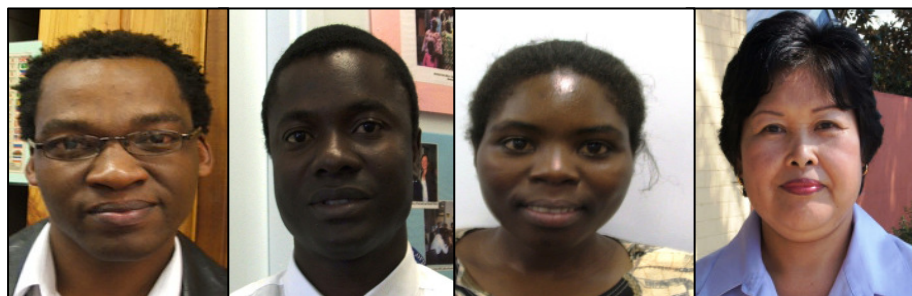
Table 1: African Youth Project Clients in the Newcastle, Lake Macquarie and Maitland area.



The above table indicates the numbers of young people the project is currently working with. Sudanese young people are the largest group with 75% of all clients being Sudanese however the project has been able to support youths from all African refugee communities in the Newcastle and Hunter regions. The good relationship this project has with school provides relatively easy access to the client group.

In conclusion this project has been able to support young African refugees in a range of activities as well as focus and support other agencies on the direct needs of African young people. It has also assisted with the development of strategies to support African youths and to encourage these youths to support themselves.

Marial Fieg
African Youth Worker



African Family Support Workers

Funded by Department of Community Services

Zach Ekandi, Mohamed Kamara, Joselyne Ntamomvukiye & Zenaida Edmunds

The aim of this project is to assist African parents and families with children up to five years of age to access services such as health, finance, training, education and cultural practices. It also aims to assist parents and families to develop parenting skills, confidence and self esteem.

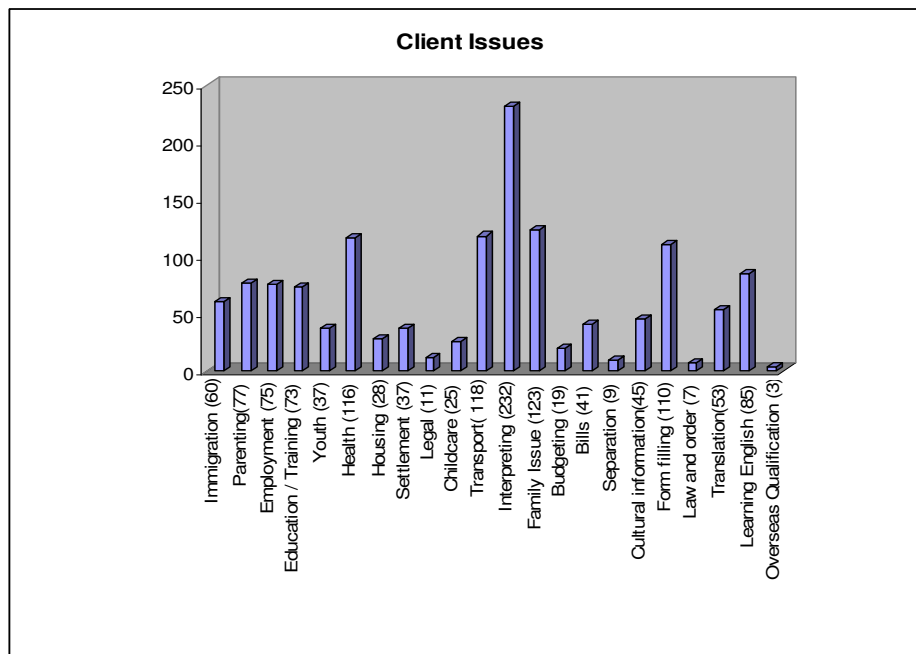
This project is now in its 3rd year of funding, being initially funded for a period of 12 months in April 2005, as an enhancement of the Families First Project. The target population for the project has been families with young children under 5 and the key communities supported by the project are the Burundi, Liberian, Sierra Leonean, Congolese, and Rwandan, as well as some Sudanese families.

The range of linguistic and cultural needs presented by such diverse families has required flexible and innovative approaches to service delivery and as a result several people have been employed to deliver services in the most accessible way. One of the original workers Ibrahim Nduwamunga developed very effective linkages with the Burundi community which certainly presented as a high needs community in the family formation stage of life. This emphasis has continued because of ongoing settlement issues being experienced by this group, so we have ensured that the needs of Kirundi and Swahili speaking groups have continue to be addressed, through the employment of bilingual workers. We also felt that the presence of female workers would also be more appropriate to the needs of women and children.

The AFS workers have been involved in the development and support of a wide range of activities. These include;

- Conducted home visits to support families with young children
- Provided play and learning experiences to the children such as craft, education, good behaviour and hygiene.
- Provided a training session with the mothers on nutrition for children.
- Provided information to the mothers regarding the different alternatives in disciplining children.
- Organised a series of health sessions with the mothers, addressing children's immunization, vaccination, first –aid at home with young children, and other health issues, (these sessions are still continuing).
- Field trips to festivals, restaurants and picnics.
- Sewing classes.
- Establishing a women's choir and perform at the Multicultural Variety Concert, held at Newcastle City Hall on the 9th of September.
- Assisting with School Readiness Program and Transition to School Programs.

In addition to these activities a number of other support services have been carried out including general casework, support and referrals and home visits. The issues presented from the Burundi community are detailed in the table overleaf:



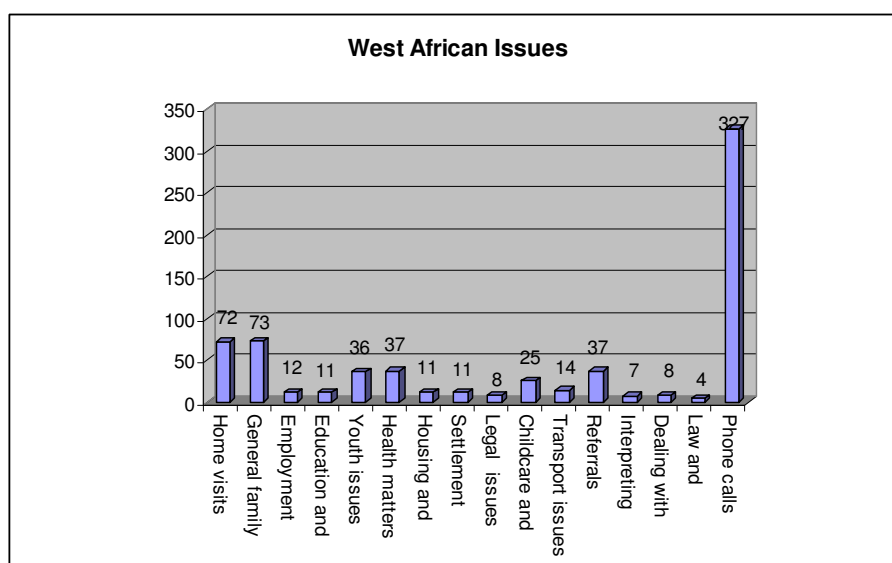
Due to an increasing number of young families in the local Liberian community, Mohamed Kamara has been employed 3 days per week to work with the West African families, with the following achievements occurring;

- Delivery of parenting and general information sessions
- Establishment of the West African kids and mums group
- Establishment of the West African Cultural and hip hop dance group

Other daily activities conducted include:

- Home visits to provide support to young parents and families with children under or up to five years of age
- Provide support in safe parenting skills and house maintenance
- Dealing with childcare arrangements
- Tenancy and accommodation assistance
- Form filling and community information dissemination

Issues presented from the West African community since April 2007 are detailed in the table below:



Zach Ekandi, Mohamed Kamara, Joselyne Ntahomvukiye & Zeni Edmunds



Volunteer Resource Worker

Paul Sidebottom

The purpose of this part-time position, funded by NSS, is to recruit, train and coordinate the activities of the volunteers working with refugee families. This report covers the period September 2006 to August 2007. The year's activities can be summarised under the following headings:

Recruitment

From September 2006 until the time of writing this report, 122 enquiries about volunteering have been received and 68 volunteers have signed up. A further 3 volunteers were referred to other agencies.

In the same period, 44 volunteers withdrew. The main reasons were: ill-health; starting full-time work; moving out of the area; and doing other types of volunteer work.

All new volunteers signed a Prohibited Persons Employment Declaration and, where appropriate, had a NSW Police check.

Currently there are 150 volunteers on the 'active' list, and a further 28 on leave.

Training

The following training sessions were held during the year:

September 2006	Debriefing of school volunteers and Presentation of awards.
October 2006	Interagency session, by Red Cross, on volunteer response to disasters.
February 2007	Two training and induction sessions for current and new VISP tutors.
May 2007	Training session for all volunteers on tutoring methods. Led by Dr Bob Conway, Assoc. Prof. of Education at Newcastle University

Community Refuge Support Group (CRS):

This group meets at NSS on the last Monday evening of each month. CRS provides a forum for volunteers to discuss their work, and also has information sessions relevant to volunteer activities. Guest speakers this year have covered Cultural differences, the Health system, Red Cross Tracing service, Surf Lifesaving and Water Safety, Disability Advocacy and descriptions of everyday life in Sudan, Liberia and Sierra Leone.

Two social outings have also been held; 110 people attended a Christmas picnic at Jesmond Park, and a brave 9 came to the very wet picnic in June.

Homework and Study Centre

A number of language support classes were held at Hamilton Public School during the school holidays in January. The program was offered by NSS, DET and HEPTACLS. 49 students and 30 tutors attended over the three weeks.

As a result of the success of the January classes, a Homework and Study Centre was set up at the same venue. This has operated each Wednesday afternoon from 4.00 p.m. to 5.30 p.m. On average, 10-12 students and 5-8 tutors work each week.

In June, a grant of \$6000 was received from the Uniting Church Innovative Community Grants program. This will be used to buy resources and teaching aids for the Centre.

An extension of this Homework Centre concept has led to two volunteer support groups being set up at Callaghan College, Jesmond Campus. These groups work on Monday and Wednesday afternoons.

Myall Road Store

The large shed behind the houses at No.1 Myall Rd has been cleaned up and the material sorted and catalogued. The shed is now locked and keys, and an inventory of contents, are available from the Volunteer Coordinator.

Blog

A “web log” (a.k.a. BLOG) has been set up as a means of communication between volunteers and the refugee community. While still in its early days, the blog provides information on volunteering, refugee needs, and current events. Access to the blog is by <http://nssvolunteers.blogspot.com>

Programs

The table shows the main volunteer activities for the year, and the number of volunteers involved in each.

Program	No of Volunteers	Activities
Families	43	Helping families with shopping, budgeting, homecare, English language support, social support and any other problems.
Home Tutoring	28	Providing study support for students at home. Students range from primary school to University.
VISP	29	Volunteers in Schools Program. Providing support for refugee students in classrooms in 13 DET schools.
Homework & Study Centre	15	Both students and tutors operate on a ‘drop in’ basis.
Driving supervision / Transport	21	Provide some transport to medical appointments and clinics. Also provide supervision for clients on their “L”s
Sewing/Craft groups	5	Assisting in weekly sewing groups with Sudanese, Burundian and Liberian women.
Conversation classes	1	A new conversation class for Burundian women going for their driving licences is in the process of being set up.
General or Community Work	11	A range of activities including setting up and maintaining computers, psychological counselling, household repairs, gardening, repairing bicycles, teaching music, driver training, etc.
Onward referrals	3	Volunteers referred onwards to NAALA (the Samaritans Saturday morning English school), Home Tutor, HomeStart, Aged Care work, or community organisations.
On leave, or awaiting assignment	28	

As well as the programs listed above, volunteers have carried out many jobs over the year, ranging from giving piano lessons, to cataloguing and storing donations, to repairing bicycles and the myriad of small tasks that always seem to be coming up. Their enthusiasm, energy and commitment are truly amazing. It has been a privilege to work with them.

Without the support of the staff at NSS, and my fellow workers in ‘Team Africa’, only a fraction of the programs listed would have run as effectively. It has been a pleasure and inspiration to work in such an organisation, with such dedicated people.

Paul Sidebottom, Volunteer Resource Worker.

WELFARE

TEAM

Ms Pet M.C. Kelly
Filipino Welfare Worker
Welfare Team Leader

Ms Elena Ferguson
Russian Welfare Worker

Ms Nellie Srisurapon
Thai Welfare Worker

Ms Juanita Loli
Samoan Welfare Worker

Ms Sara Stankovic
Tongan Welfare Worker

Ms Zenaida Edmunds
Migrant and Refugee Women's Worker

Ms Devika Wijewardene
Multicultural Family Worker



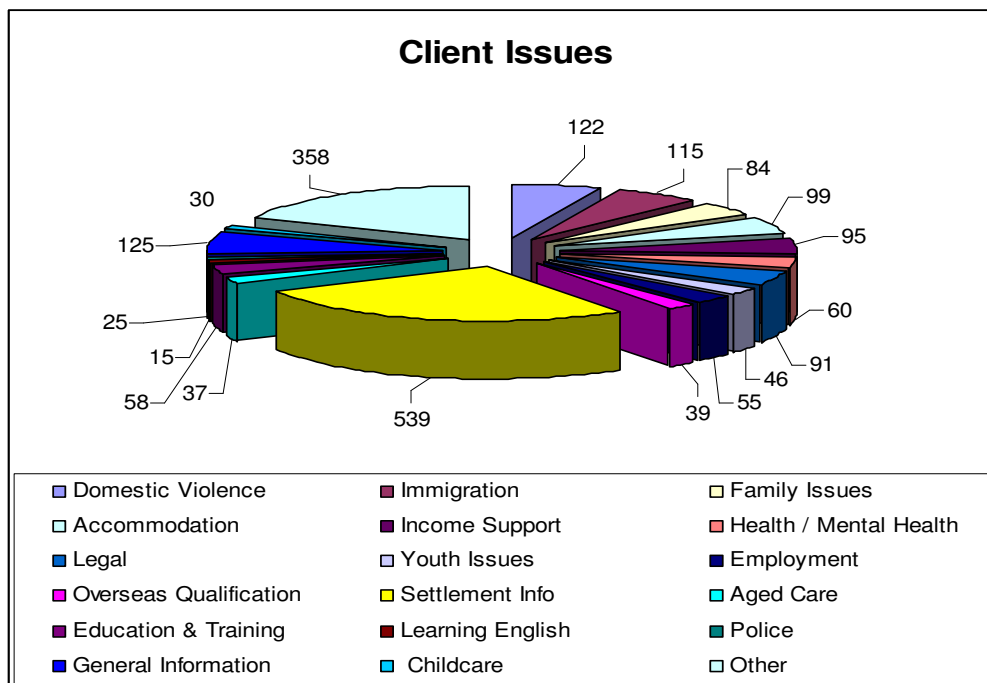
Filipino Welfare Project

Pet M. C. Kelly

Funded by Department of Community Services

Preparing and writing the AGM report allows me to reflect and assess the work I've done during the year. And as I reflect, I realised the successes and challenges of the service we do. However, the continued complexity of the job has strengthened us again.

This year, the Filipino Welfare Project provided approximately **1993** instances of services to clients. Their issues are inter-related in many cases and on many occasions, a client presented a number of needs/problems. The issues faced by clients are described in the following chart:

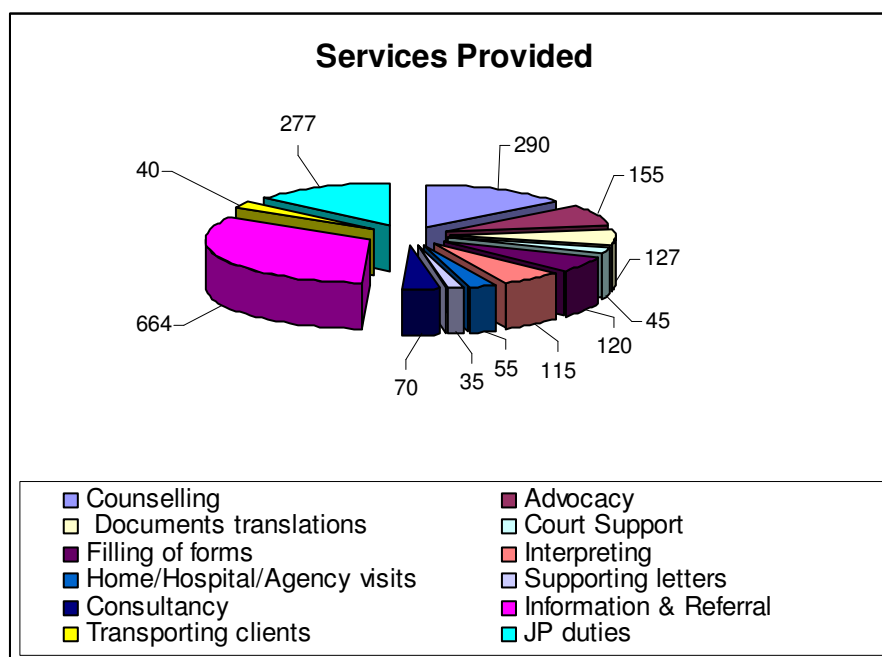


TOTAL ISSUES PRESENTED 1993

Other includes social/emotional, death/bereavement/ separation/divorce, gambling problem, harassment/ discrimination, neighbourhood dispute, income tax return, supporting letters, transport difficulties, language difficulties, filling in forms, court support, access to belongings, passport renewals, translation of documents, JP signature, referee, real estate, etc.

As can be seen from the statistics, client settlement information forms a significant part of my work. Likewise, domestic violence, immigration, accommodation and housing, financial and legal matters predominate as problem areas.

SERVICES PROVIDED

**COMMUNITY DEVELOPMENT:**

During the year a number of information sessions were organised for the Filipino Women's Group at the NSS. These are the following:

- Domestic Violence and Apprehended Violence Orders (AVO)
- Genetic Counselling on Breast & Ovarian Cancer
- Making Choices
- Sleeping Problems
- Use of Medication
- Healthy Eating
- Dental Health
- Alternative Medicine
- Eye Problem
- Dual Citizenship
- Coordinated the Filipino Choir of Newcastle

OTHER ACTIVITIES:

Throughout the year, I attended the following seminars, training, meetings, etc.:

- Staying Home Leaving Home Violence
- Supervision Skills
- Suicide prevention
- Case Management: Working with People with Complex Needs
- Working with People with Mental Illness
- Seminar by Department of Ageing, Disability & Homecare
- Good Practice Guidelines
- Demystifying Mental Illness
- Domestic Violence & Victims of Crime Compensation
- Intoxicated Person's Protocol Working Group
- Refuge Week Celebration
- Fire Prevention Training
- Jenny's Place 30th Anniversary Celebration
- Multicultural Forums (Centrelink)
- Newcastle Interagency Meeting

Once again, I had a busy, but satisfying year. I would like to thank my colleagues for their encouragement and support. Likewise, the Northern Settlement Services Ltd. Board of Management for their most valued support to the Filipino Welfare Project.

Pet M. C. Kelly , Social Worker, Welfare Team Leader

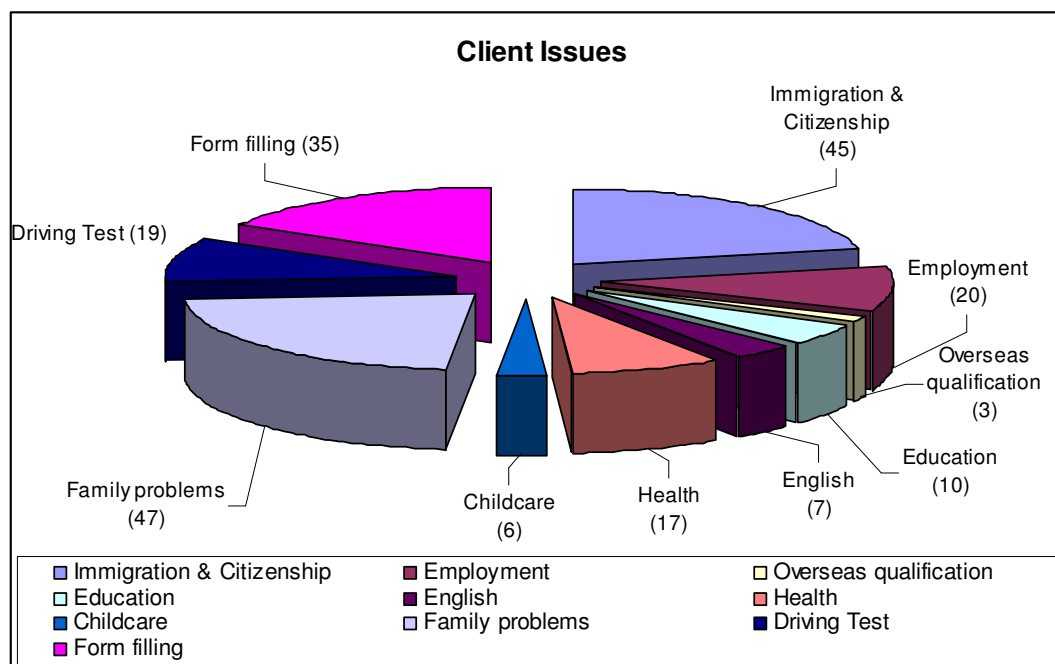


Russian Welfare Worker

Elena Ferguson

Funded by Department of Community Services

My report covers the period from May 2007 to November 2007, during this time the Russian Welfare Project had approximately 213 cases each case had between five and eight separate issues to deal with. The Russian welfare worker was available at NSS for two days each week.



This chart shows a predominance of clients seeking help with family problems (47), which are a result of lack of family support owing to the great distance from Russia and the very large cultural differences. The other major issue was Immigration/Citizenship (45). Assistance with form filling (35) accessing translation services (20) are two of the major issues with which the service can assist. Driving licence issues (19) and Health (17) were the other two major issues which for new arrivals. Other issues which presented during this period were Child care, Education, Recognition of Overseas qualifications, Employment and other miscellaneous issues.

My job is to develop information packages for the new arrivals in Australia and their supporters, and to help Russian people obtain information. This information includes: "How to access local events", "Aged services", "The NSS immigration advice service", "Health information", as well as services that are available from Centrelink.

Face-to-face counselling, information, advice, assistance with forms, translation, consultancy, home visits and referral of service were given to the Russian speakers to help them in dealing with: Centrelink, Hunter Area Health, Multicultural Neighbourhood Centre, TAFE, Australian Business Institution, Migration advice and assistance. In working together with these services I was able to provide assistance and support to the clients.

I attended the following meetings to provide cultural awareness, on request, to mainstream service providers, so that they can enhance their services to Russian speakers:

Centrelink Multicultural Forum, Workshop on Introduction to Loss and Grief, Homeless Forum, Mental Illness session Hunter CLSD Partners, Refugee Week Celebration, First Aid Course, Fire Training, Citizenship ceremony, Settlement Grants Programme information session (DIAC), Legal Seminar "Victims of Crime Compensation and Domestic Violence", NSS Planning Day, NSS staff meetings, NSS caseworkers meetings.

I identified Russian community needs by developing a survey and by interviewing people. I then consulted with the relevant agencies to develop appropriate information sessions and arrange venues and speakers. This was to assist in establishing and developing a Russian group in the Newcastle area. I organised several information sessions for the Russian community, including a "Centrelink Payments" session, "Educational" session with Austraining Business Institute and a "Health and Beauty" session. An average of **10** people attended each session. The sessions were successful with the recommendation that they be prepared regularly on settlement issues.

A Russian language Newsletter is published on a monthly basis, providing settlement information for new arrivals. The vocational sessions and programs for cultural cooking classes and craft classes were established. An Arts program has been developed for Russian children to enable them to express themselves on a weekly basis (children's musical group). The Russian school is continued its lessons and the adult musical group has just been established and is developing.

During this six months of my work I assisted in arranging social support activities for the following events: Russian Victory Day (II War), Christmas in July (musical, concert and games), Picnic with fun and games, Celebration of 1st of September- "Russian School Day", Dinners held at the Russian church where people of all generations gather together and share their experiences about immigration issues. **35-56** people have attended each of these activities and they are saying that social life is playing a major role in establishing and developing a Russian group in the Newcastle area and helping new arrivals feel involved in this new country.

Conclusions

The main issues were language problems and translation, referrals and family problems, health and general information. The number of instances of service shows that the Russian community values the services being offered to them and are working hard to settle well into Australian society. I helped establish the free computer class for 4 people, who will receive a Certificate 2 in Information Technology. It will help to find them work and give them a qualification to build on. However, much work is still to be done to help the community improve their language knowledge which will enable them to get into the workplace and other training programs.

Elena Ferguson
Russian Welfare Worker



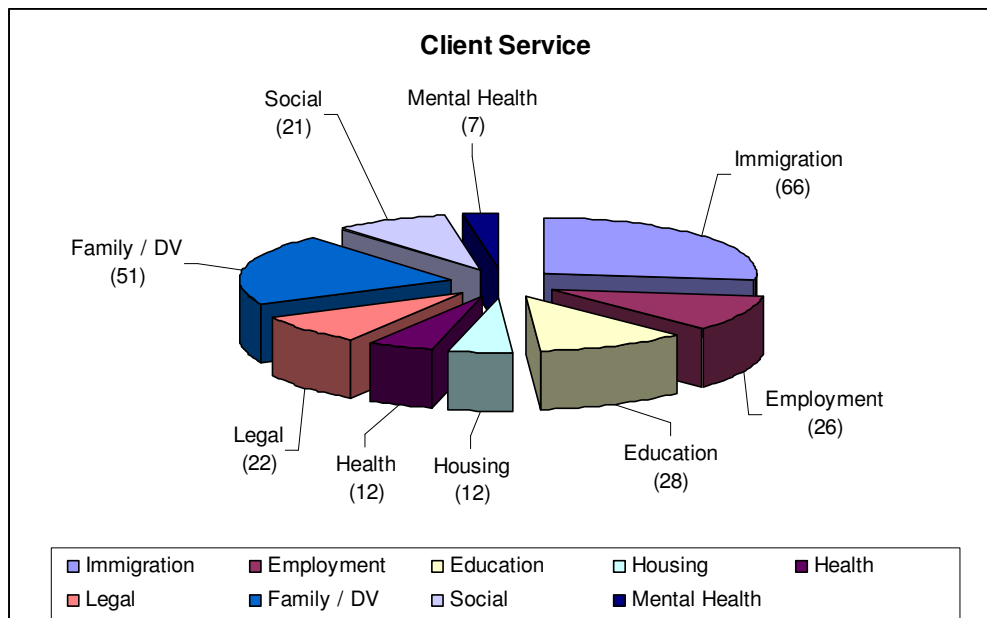
THAI WELFARE PROJECT

Nellie Srisurapon

Funded by Department of Community Services

Currently, in the Newcastle and Upper and Lower Hunter regions, there are 250 - 300 Thai people resident. This number is steadily increasing. Regular contact is made with the Thai community through mail outs to about 130 households. These mail outs provide information on a variety of services and activities in both Thai and English.

Clients and professionals are able to seek assistance or advice 7 days a week by telephone. Tuesdays are available for face to face meetings with people in the Thai community at the NSS offices. The occasions of service, either face to face or by telephone, for the period of Nov 06 to Oct 07 are as follows:



These figures do not include 7 weeks over Dec 06 – Jan 07 period.

About 90% of the community seeking assistance are women. The remaining 10% are Thai men and Australian men married to Thai women, in some cases seeking help on cross cultural communication issues.

Home Visits

Visits to clients at their homes are usually because they have no access to transport. Some have required assistance moving house quickly while others need some emotional support.

Women's meetings

These meetings are usually held once a month, at times with a guest speaker, or at times a relaxed session where written information is handed out and those more isolated can meet with friends. All family members are welcome to the meetings there can be 8 – 20 in attendance.

Mail outs

We have a compiled mail list of 133 Thai households. Information on a variety of issues such as Law, Social Security and Health are sent in the Thai language. Notices of educational courses and cultural activities are also sent out. At times, information is sent out on an individual needs basis. This is also useful in linking isolated Thai people with each other in a particular area and also to find work in that area. The Thai consulate has also forwarded, through me, information on Thai elections. All addresses are confidential.

Interpreting Assistance

This assistance has been given to the Migration agents at NSS when providing services for Thai clients, both in Australia and overseas, submitting visa applications.

Religious Ceremonies

4 times this year cultural ceremonies were held at a local hall. Buddhist monks from a temple in Sydney are invited to give sermon. These events are well supported in the community. This is not only an opportunity for the community to come together but to give individual support or advice to those in need. Written information in Thai regarding services in the area is handed out. Attendance can be 80 to 120 people.

Cultural Evening

NSS gives some support to the Thai community to commemorate the Kings birthday in December. Displays of cultural music and dance with support of various Thai government. and non government organizations. The Thai community raises money for charities in Thailand and Australia.

Workshops attended

Grief and Bereavement
Domestic Violence
Legal Aid
NSS Planning Day

Nellie Srisurapon

Thai Welfare Worker



PACIFIC ISLANDER WELFARE
Juanita Loli & Sara Stankovic
Funded by the Department of Community Services

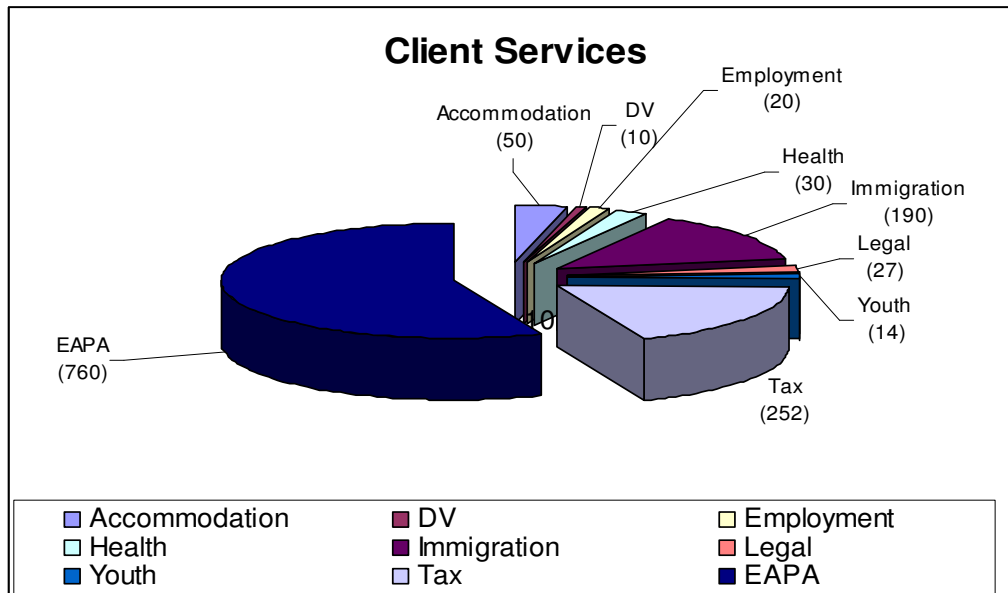
The Pacific Islander Welfare Project has been in operation since 1990 under the umbrella of NSS (or MRC as it was then), and was managed by its own Management Committee (PIWC) and funded by the Department of Community Services (DOCS). This Project employed two workers to provide assistance to Pacific Islanders with issues relating to accommodation & housing, domestic violence, employment, health, immigration (citizenship applications & sponsorship), legal, youth, and providing information and referrals as well advocacy.

The two workers aim to achieve objectives of:

1. Supporting children, young people, individual and families of Pacific Islanders to enable the enhancement of their independence, safety, self-esteem and or quality of life within the communities by:
 - i) providing information, advice, referrals and advocacy to individuals and families.
 - ii) providing group work to the Pacific Island Women's Groups attended by 25 – 35 women.
 - iii) providing tax assistance through Tax Help Volunteer Programs (ATO)
 - iv) providing ongoing support, advocacy and casework services to client group through caseplan.
2. Building strong communities and social capital / undertaking community development so that Pacific Island Communities are well informed, resourced, and connected and that equity and diversity are embraced by:
 - i) providing information via the newsletters distributed monthly to the Samoans and bi-monthly to the Tongans. This information includes family activities in the areas the Pacific Islanders live and information regarding changes to government policies etc, the purpose being to inform Pacific Islanders and enhance awareness of the services they can access. Information is also transmitted on a weekly basis to the Samoan and Tongan Communities via the Community Radio programs on Radio 2NURFM 103.7 (Sunday nights for the Samoans & Friday nights for the Tongans) to an audience of 300 – 400 people.
 - ii) Workers also support the South Pacific Island Culture In Education (SPICE) as well as the Pacific Regional Advisory Council (PRAC) that hold Homework Centres and Cultural Group Dance Practices to help youth of Pacific Island background maintain their cultural identities.
 - iii) Workers maintain networking with government and non-government agencies and service providers by attending meetings throughout the year. Agencies and service providers include: Centrelink, Department of Housing, DOCS, Ethnic Communities Council, Hunter Tenants' Advice / Advocacy Service, Legal Aid, Migrant Health Service, NSW Police, NSS Caseworkers' Meetings, NSS Staff, Centrelink Multicultural Forum, CALD COCS Advisory Group etc.

Northern Settlement Services' clients who need emergency relief or welfare assistance in paying bills i.e. Electricity, Gas, Telephone and Water are also assisted.

This statistics report is a presentation of 7 months (April – October) when Northern Settlement Services took over the management of this project from the Pacific Islanders Welfare Committee (PIWC).



Clients who visit the Office to obtain assistance with Tax Returns and Welfare / Emergency Relief are not all of Pacific Island Background but are either Anglo Saxons with low income or Centrelink recipients as well as CALD. They are either self referred or referred by other service providers / or centre based referrals. Ongoing case management provided with support given via home visits and referral to other services.

It has been a busy year and a productive one for us particularly with new and interesting clients visiting the Centre as well as new arrivals of Pacific Islander background migrating from New Zealand.

We very much appreciate the support of the Director and Admin Staff and also our Team Leader. We enjoy working with such a wonderful staff. We wish you all a safe and happy break for Christmas and New Year.

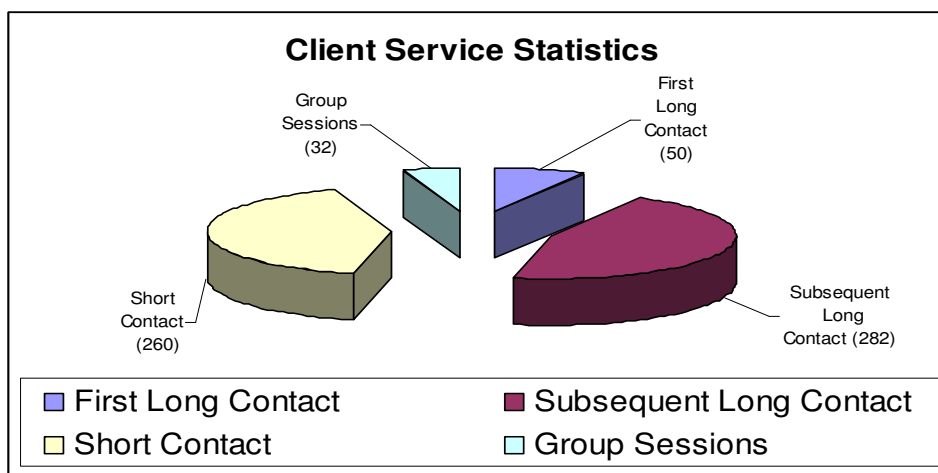
Juanita Loli Samoan Welfare Worker
Sara Stankovic Tongan Welfare Worker



**Migrant and Refugee Women's Support Worker
Settlement Grants Program
Funded by Department of Immigration and Citizenship
Zenaïda Edmunds**

This is a joint project between Northern Settlement Services (NSS) and the Multicultural Neighbourhood Centre (MNC) and it is funded for 2 years from July 2006 to June 2008. The aim of the project is to assist the settlement of newly arrived migrant women and women who have arrived under the humanitarian program. The project provides casework, information, referrals and group work. Project worker is based at MNC, 3 days per week, Tuesdays, Wednesdays, and Thursdays and at NSS 1 day per week on Mondays. The project service location at the MNC is easily accessible to the target group because English classes provided by Hunter Community College are held at the centre and majority of students are women from the target group. The MNC has new premises and is easily accessible by public transport, has spacious classrooms, a computer lab, new kitchen facilities and children's playgroup facilities are also available.

Table 1: Direct Client Contact Services - January 2007 to October 2007



Casework consists mainly of domestic violence (DV) and related issues, such as accommodation, legal matters, family law court, Centrelink and police matters.

Group Work

Established the Migrant and Refugee Women's Group, who been meet once a month with attendances averaging **7-11** women from various cultural backgrounds. The Burundi Women's Group and the Burundi Women's Choir Group was established. This has made the provision of information and relevant activities to these women effective and beneficial. Attendance averages **9-12** women from this group.

Group Work Activities include;

- Cooking demonstrations
- Sharing cultural experiences
- Computer class-beginners
- Dance/Aerobics families
- Parenting session at Newcastle Family Support Services – Burundi families
- Burundi Women's Choir Group participated in the Multicultural Variety Concert
- Burundi Women's Choir invited to perform at a local café in Mayfield
- Family picnic at Newcastle Foreshore during the Mattara Festival.
- Organized a family picnic and a train trip to Maitland for Maitland Steamfest.
- Organized a Mother's Day dinner for the mothers, to experience a traditional Australian celebration of recognizing and thanking mothers.

Coffee and conversation
 Visiting Newcastle landmarks
 Digital collage
 Visit to a Pre-School –Burundi

Information Services:

- Parenting/Children's Supervision
- Parenting/Children's Safety at Home
- Parenting/Children's Healthy Lunches
- Skilled Migrants Jobseekers Information
- Tenancy Information
- Exercise/Dancing – Benefits
- Child Rearing Practices/Culture Sharing
- Fair Trading Information
- Healthy Blood Pressure/ Blood Sugar
- Children's Services in Australia, includes information about Playgroup, Children's Long Day Care Centres, Pre-Schools, Out of School Hours Care, Family Day Care, Vacation Care, and In – Home Care.

Health sessions with the Burundi women continue, these sessions are held once every fortnight and sessions are conducted by the Refugee Health Nurse from John Hunter Hospital. Health issues being addressed are vaccination, children's immunization, individual health records, blood pressure, blood sugar, nutrition, and children's health

Settlement Needs Issues Identified:

- Lack of English literacy for newly arrived migrant and refugee women is a great barrier to participation in the society. Opportunities to use English outside the home and not just in English classes needs to be provided with support, to emphasize its importance in order to participate in our mainstream society.
- Lack of transport facilities especially for families with children under five. This is certainly a deterrent for women participating in different activities, which would assist them in gaining knowledge and skills and empower them to fully participate in mainstream activities.
- Generally adjusting to Australian way of life, in terms of gender roles and responsibilities, family relationships, family finances, general hygiene, food and nutrition.

I would like to thank Alex Burns for guidance and direction, and Amany Beshay, MNC manager for providing ongoing support and technical assistance.

Zenaida Edmunds, Migrant Women's Worker



Multicultural Family Support Project (Families First)

Devika Wijewardene

Funded by the Department of Community Services

During this year a total of **51** families have accessed this service from the Newcastle and Lake Macquarie areas. Of this **19** families received assistance outside of office hours. Of all the **51** families who accessed the service either one or both parents were from culturally and linguistically diverse backgrounds.

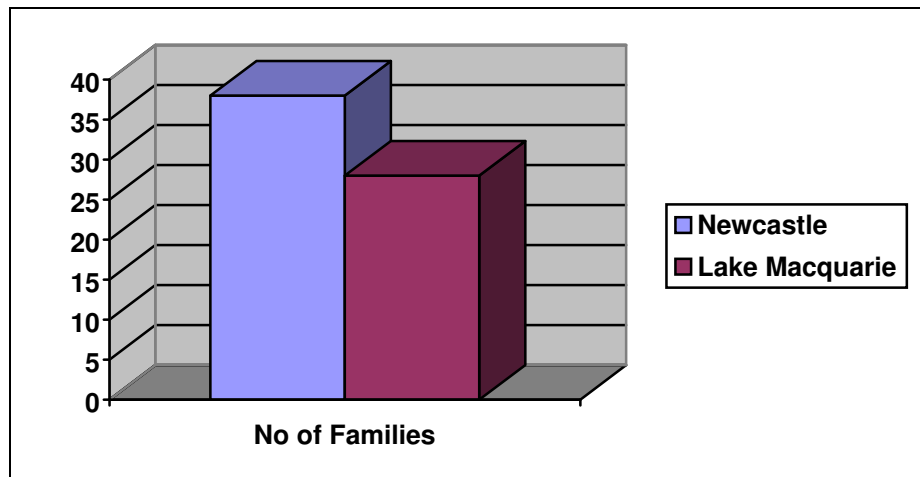
During this period clients from **21** countries were assisted.

Types of issues presented: (Each family would have one or more of the following issues)

Assistance Provided	<i>No of instances</i>
Domestic Violence	26
Housing Issues	22
Legal Issues	9
Isolation	34
Child/mother with disability	22
Antenatal/postnatal needs	7
Mental Health	17
Immigration Issues	24
Material/ Financial	29
Home Visits	58

Services worked with / Networking

Hunter Home Start/ Family In Sight
 Multicultural Health Unit
 Hunter New England Area Health
 Hunter Family Support Service
 Early Childhood Centres
 Department of Community Services
 Multicultural Neighbourhood Centre
 Women's Refuges
 NewMacq Housing
 Eva's Project
 Women's Housing
 Ethnic Communities Council
 Child Care Centres
 Family Day Care Newcastle/Lake Macquarie
 Uniting Church
 Disability and Advocacy Service
 Legal Aid

Figure 1: Clients from Newcastle and Lake Macquarie areas:

Case Management

Clients accessed this service through referrals from other services, through self referrals, Centre based referrals and through other clients who had support from this service.

On going case management was provided for the clients with support through home visits, counselling, by accompanying families to appointments and linking them to other appropriate services to achieve the best outcome for the clients.

Parenting Sessions for clients was conducted with Newcastle family support and others sessions were supported for parents with preschool children with Samaritans. Other sessions included Home Start Newcastle and Family In Sight formerly Hunter Home Start.

It has been a very productive year for this project and I would like to thank the Director, staff and the management committee for their support.

Devika Wijewardene
Multicultural Family Worker
(Families First)



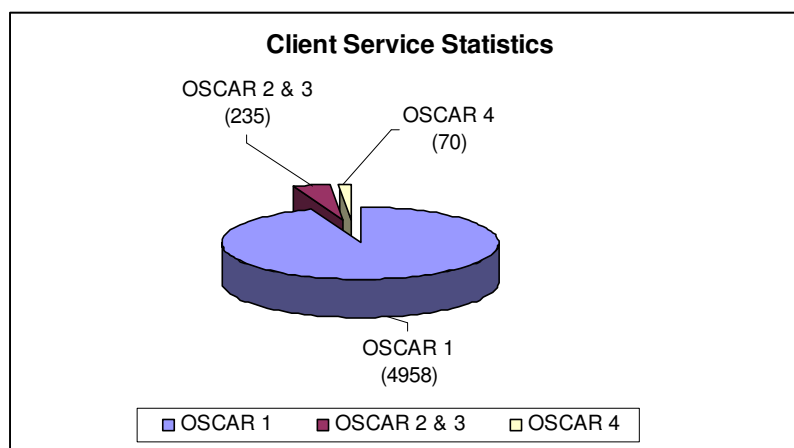
INFORMATION & REFERRAL SERVICE

Tima 'Oto & Sinead Buckley
Funded by the Department of Immigration & Citizenship

The information and referral service provides information and casework services to newly arrived refugees and migrants within the Newcastle and Hunter SSD's

Client record statistics reflect direct dealings with clients handled by core staff and the casework relating to clients referred onwards, internally and externally, as well as sessions offered throughout the year to the target group.

Recorded client services



OSCAR 1 Short contacts -there were **4958** occasions of service where client needs were met directly by the administration team **or** were referred internally to another NSS worker **or** were referred externally to another organisation.

OSCAR 2 & 3 First or subsequent long contacts

Casework on this project averages 7 hours per week with an average of **19** clients per month and a total of **235** occasions of service. Casework includes reading mail and writing letter on behalf of clients, making phone calls, completing application forms, family issues, budgeting, payment of bills and assisting clients to access other mainstream services and citizenship.

Citizenship

145 applications for Australian citizenship have been processed this year with an increase in the numbers of applications being made in the run up to the new citizenship test. Some confusion has been expressed, however, by our clients about the eligibility requirements under the new laws. From October 1, 2007 all applicants for Australian citizenship (with few exceptions) are required to complete the citizenship test.

Group sessions - 70 in total comprising the following groups:

- African Women's Sewing Group
- African Female Youth
- Volunteers In Schools Program
- West African Mothers Group

Tima 'Oto & Sinead Buckley

NSS CORE STAFF MEMBERS 2007



ARLENE RICHARDS
Financial Controller



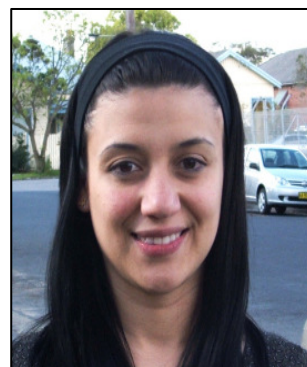
SINEAD BUCKLEY
Office Manager



MARIANNE MOHR
Asst Financial Controller



RENEE MCLEAN
Administration



SILVIA RUANO
Administration



HELEN BUCHANAN
OH & S Consultant



MICHAEL FREUND
Volunteer Resource Worker
Replaced P Sidebottom Oct 2007

CENTRE USAGE 2007

African Community Council	Letlessi
African Sewing Group	Migrant Health Unit
Ba'hai Community of Newcastle	Multicultural Dementia Carers Group
Bosnian Community of Newcastle	Newcastle & Hunter Ethnic Choral Society
Burundi Dance Group	Newcastle Theatre Company
Burundi Community of Newcastle	Newcastle Akebono Japanese Group
Burundi & Congolese Community	New Arrival Welcomes
Centrelink Multicultural Forum	Pacific RAC
Community Refugee Support	Russian Women's Group
DIAC Immigration Officers Field visits	Russian School
Estonian Community of Newcastle	Russian Mothers and Babies
Filipino Community Choir	Samoan Women's Group
Filipino Women's Group	Slovenian Association of Newcastle "Tivoli"
First Aid Group	Spanish Group
French Group	STARTTS Counselling
Greek Macedonian Brotherhood Pavlos Melas	Sudanese Community of Newcastle
Hamilton Multicultural Walkers	Tamil Language School
Hamilton Olympic Soccer Club	Tongan Choir
Hunter Refugee Network	Tongan Health Sessions
Hunter Community Legal Clinic	United Nations Association
Migrant Interagency	Volunteers in Schools Program
International Choir	
Latvian Group	

2007 at Northern Settlement Services



Above:
A group of volunteers and refugees meet for a Coffee Morning in Armidale.

Below:
Newcastle African Soccer Team “The Flying Eagles” train at Islington Park





Above: Young African children attend sewing group with their Mothers at NSS



Above: Families attend a picnic at Jesmond Park hosted by NSS volunteers

